



SOLE CAPITAL OF A.P.

Govt. to table Bill on Amaravati in LS

SOUTH » PAGE 7

SUMMER TIME

Parts of India to see more heatwave days, says IMD

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SEMICONDUCTOR ECOSYSTEM

Sanand a bridge to Silicon Valley: Modi

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OPPOSITION'S MOVE

An impeachment motion with no winners

It shows breakdown in confidence in CEC, EC

OPINION » PAGE 9



ACING THE CHASE

Connolly delivers for Kings in a thriller

SPORT » PAGE 15

Trump blasts allies, tells them ‘go get your own oil’

U.S. President accuses NATO partners of not being there for America during the war on Iran; he tells countries they can either buy fuel from the U.S. or go to the Strait of Hormuz to pick it up

Sriram Lakshman
LONDON

U.S. President Donald Trump lashed out at allies on Tuesday telling them to fend for themselves regarding oil supplies, adding to the pressure within the Western military alliance, NATO, whose members have not joined the U.S. and Israel in their war on Iran.

Mr. Trump accused allies of not being there for the U.S. and encouraged countries to take the oil from the Strait of Hormuz, the crucial waterway bordering Iran that Tehran has mostly blocked off. The President's messages came as oil prices have been surging and hours after the UAE's authorities reported a drone attack on an oil tanker off Dubai.

"All of those countries that can't get jet fuel because of the Strait of Hormuz, like the United Kingdom, which refused to get involved in the decapitation of Iran, I have a suggestion for you: Number 1, buy from the U.S., we have plenty, and Number 2, build up some delayed courage, go to the Strait, and just TAKE IT," Mr.



Assessing damage: Members of the Red Crescent Society working at the site of an attack in Tehran on Tuesday. REUTERS

Trump wrote on the Truth Social site, early Tuesday morning Washington time. "You'll have to start learning how to fight for yourself, the U.S.A. won't be there to help you anymore, just like you weren't there for us. Iran has been, essentially, decimated. The hard part is done. Go get your own oil!" Mr. Trump added.

In recent weeks, the President has been at odds with the position of U.K. Prime Minister on Iran and the fallout of the war, after spending the larger part of last year embracing Mr. Starmer and the U.K.-U.S. "special relationship"

since his return to the White House.

However, Mr. Trump, in a subsequent post, said he "greatly respected" Britain's King Charles III and looked forward to welcoming the King and Queen on a state visit to Washington at the end of the month. Buckingham Palace confirmed the visit.

The U.K. government has used the British Royal Family as a diplomatic tool with Mr. Trump, including by hosting him for a second state visit in the U.K. last year.

Asked for a reaction to Mr. Trump's statements, Downing Street directed

'Iran has will to end war, but needs guarantees'

TEHRAN Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian said on Tuesday his country had the "necessary will" to end the ongoing war with Israel and the United States, but was seeking guarantees that the conflict would not be repeated. "The solution to normalising the situation is the cessation of their aggressive attacks," Mr. Pezeshkian said. » PAGE 14

The Hindu to Mr. Starmer's words on a visit to Finland last week. There, the Prime Minister had focused on Russia's war with Ukraine saying there was a "war on two fronts", in Ukraine and Iran. Russian President Vladimir Putin was benefiting from the war in West Asia, Mr. Starmer had said, as he urged the harder pursuit of Russia's 'shadow fleet' of oil-carrying vessels in European waters, circumventing Western sanctions.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10
'CAULDRON OF CONFLICT' » PAGE 8

Boycott NDA to protect TN's rights, says Stalin

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUVARUR

DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Tuesday launched his campaign for the Tamil Nadu Assembly election at a rally in Tiruvarur by calling upon the people of the State to boycott the [AIADMK-led] National Democratic Alliance (NDA) and rise above political differences to support the DMK-led alliance "to protect the rights of the State".

"We will surpass our achievements in the Dravidan Model 2.0 government and take Tamil Nadu to greater heights. On the day of voting, you only need to decide whether you want the anti-Tamil, opportunistic NDA or the continuation of the achievements of the DMK government," he told the electorate.

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 6

Eight killed in Bihar temple stampede



Tragic incident: People receive treatment in a hospital after the stampede at Sheetla Mata Temple in Bihar's Nalanda district. ANI

Amarnath Tewary
PATNA

At least eight people, mostly women devotees, were killed and several others injured in a stampede at the Sheetla Mata Temple in Nalanda district of Bihar on Tuesday.

The government has ordered a probe into the incident, which occurred in outgoing Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar's home district. Police officers at the Deep Nagar station have been suspended. Some local residents

claimed that security at the temple was short-handed as most of the district's police personnel had been deployed for President Droupadi Murmu's visit to a university just a few kilometres away.

Others blamed the temple management for taking bribes to allowing devotees to bypass the queue.

Mr. Kumar, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Murmu expressed grief over the incident.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10

NEARBY



AIADMK will eradicate ganja from TN.: EPS

SIVAKASI Within three months of returning to power, the AIADMK government will eradicate ganja from the State, party general secretary, Edappadi K. Palaniswami, said. » PAGE 6

Vijay does not understand TN. politics: Goyal

CHENNAI BJP's election in-charge for State and Union Minister Piyush Goyal on Tuesday said TVK chief C. Joseph Vijay has no understanding of the people of Tamil Nadu, their culture, and politics. » PAGE 6

OPPORTUNITIES PAGE 5
► Over 120 Jobs in today's issue

India can comfortably cater to PNG demand: govt.

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

India can comfortably cater to the demand of as many as 30 crore domestic piped natural gas (PNG) connections even if it were to solely rely on its domestic production of liquefied natural gas (LNG), according to Anjan Kumar Mishra, Secretary at the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board.

He also said that the government was trying to scale up number of connections added every day.

With escalating tensions in West Asia, the government has sought to institute mechanisms for an accelerated and incentivised transition to piped gas.

The objective is to ease some pressure off the liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), supplies of which have been affected.

Speaking to The Hindu on the sidelines of industry body PHD Chamber of Commerce and Industry's Hydrocarbon Summit, Mr. Mishra said India had approximately 1.1-1.2 crore active domestic PNG connections. These connections consumed 3 million metric standard cubic meters of natural gas per day.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 10

India's Leading International Machine Tools Exhibition



INTERNATIONAL MACHINE TOOL FAIR



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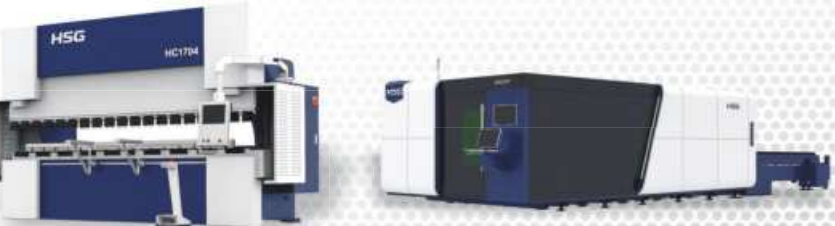
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A CH-CE



Political foray: Actor Vijayakant displaying the party flag after launching the DMOK in Madurai on September 14, 2005. THE HINDU ARCHIVES

Actor-politicians and their crusade against corruption

B. Aravind Kumar
CHENNAI

Actor and TVK founder C. Joseph Vijay’s anti-corruption plank is nothing new as the film stars floating their own parties in Tamil Nadu have taken up the same theme to cut a name for themselves and to garner a massive vote. After he launched ADMK (later AIADMK) in 1972, M.G. Ramachandran said the DMK leaders had rejected his demand for disclosure of assets by partymen. Asked about Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi’s statement that he had been given time to “express regret”, MGR said he would not express regret as long as he lived. Instead, the DMK leaders should express regret, he added.

When he landed in Coimbatore in November, the police had a tough time as the partymen broke the barricades and stormed the aircraft in which he landed. At a public meeting in Tiruppur, he announced that the ADMK-CPI agitation would “paralyse” the DMK government. When he asked the crowd if they were ready for any sacrifice to remove the corrupt and bureaucratic DMK from power, the crowd responded in the affirmative in one voice.

When Jayalalithaa floated her faction, AIADMK (Jayalalitha), in 1989 after the death of her mentor MGR, she promised in her election manifesto a clean and efficient government. “A new era in Tamil Nadu politics was ushered in when MGR was in the saddle for 11 years. But after he fell seriously ill in 1984, there was chaos and confusion and people around him exploited his physical incapacity. Following his death, the corrupt elements have remained in a faction and the responsibility has fallen on the AIADMK (Jayalalitha) to pursue the crusade of MGR. It will be the party’s commitment to the electorate to establish MGR’s rule, committed to the welfare of the people,” the manifesto said.

Corruption charges

However, her first government (1991-96) faced numerous corruption charges and eventually Jayalalithaa herself was prosecuted for acquiring wealth disproportionate to the known sources of her income. Her close aide V.K. Sasikala went to jail, while charges against Jayalalithaa “abated” after her death.

MDMK founder Vijayakant was another anti-corruption crusader. The actor-turned politician said he would not rest without putting a full stop to the “injustice” meted out to the people by the two main Dravidian parties – the DMK and the AIADMK – over the years. During his campaigns in 2006, he often stuck to his slogan on his pet theme of corruption by the Dravidian majors. “The fight against the British was *vellaiyane veliyeru* [the Quit India Movement]. Now, it’s time for us to oust the corrupt forces, so it is *kollaiyane veliyeru*,” was his slogan. He attacked the DMK and the AIADMK as evil forces. But he was in alliance with the AIADMK for the 2011 Assembly election and went on to become Leader of the Opposition.

‘Between the good and the evil’

He was heading a new alliance, called People’s Welfare Front, ahead of the 2016 Assembly election. He said both the DMK and the AIADMK had cheated the people for decades. “This is a battle between the good and the evil,” he said, terming the third front an alternative to the corrupt parties. “My alliance is with people” was his catch-phrase from the time he started his party in 2005.

Cut to the present, and Mr. Vijay has latched on to the anti-corruption campaign, targeting mainly the ruling DMK. This February, he likened criticism directed at him to attacks faced by MGR when founded the AIADMK in 1972 and mocked the DMK and other parties for repeating the criticism that he was a political novice. Introducing his party candidates, he declared that the contest was between the TVK and the “dangerously corrupt” DMK.

BJP may try to split the DMK even if it gets a majority, says VCK president

‘I wanted to contest in the Assembly election since 2021. How we function in the Assembly shapes the public perception. Going to Parliament is an honour. But, when I look at Tamil Nadu politics, the BJP’s strategy of gradually weakening regional parties and establishing itself is a cause for concern’

INTERVIEW

Thol. Thirumavalavan

Udhav Naig

Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) president Thol. Thirumavalavan, in an interview to The Hindu, defended his decision to return to the State electoral field after successfully contesting in the Lok Sabha elections. He also expressed apprehension that the BJP might engineer a split in the DMK in the future. Edited excerpts:

The VCK had sought seats in double digit and a Rajya Sabha seat from the DMK. Are you happy with the eight Assembly seats allotted to you?

We expected at least 10 seats. Unexpectedly, many parties joined the alliance, especially the DMDK and smaller parties. The leader of the alliance [the DMK] was compelled to accommodate everyone. Hence, even parties that have been in the alliance continuously – like the Left parties, the MDMK, and the Indian Union Muslim League – had to reduce their seats. For example, the MDMK has given up two seats. The Left parties had 6 earlier, as against five each now. In

such a situation, the DMK told us that it was willing to give us more seats, but not in double digit. Initially, it offered seven, but I sought eight. I did not want to prolong the negotiations.

Did you get the constituencies you asked for?

Usually, no party gets all the constituencies it asks for. There will be multiple parties seeking to contest from a constituency. It has to be given to someone, and the others must give way. In that sense, we first confirmed three constituencies: Kattumannarkoil, Cheyyur, and Thiruporur. Nagapattinam had already been allotted to Jawahirullah, which surprised us. We were told that our party’s deputy general secretary, Shanavas, had expressed his willingness to contest from another constituency; hence, the seat was given to the Manithaney Makkal Katchi. We got Arakkonam. We asked for Vanur, but didn’t get it; instead, we got Kallakurichi. In the southern districts, we asked for two seats. It was willing to give one: Periyakulam.

When you announced your intention to contest from Kattumannarkoil, you said Tamil Nadu politics would change



Working to plan: VCK founder Thol. Thirumavalavan says there were many who were eager to contest. But it renominated only four MLAs, with only eight seats allotted to the party. S. SHIVA RAJ

significantly after this election. What do you think will change?

I wanted to contest the Assembly election since 2021. What we speak and how we function in the Assembly has a big impact. A party’s actions in the Assembly shape the public perception. Going to Parliament is an honour. However, when I look at Tamil Nadu politics, the BJP’s strategy of gradually weakening regional parties and establishing itself is a cause for concern. The Prime Minister refers to the AIADMK-led alliance as the National Democratic Alliance. After the election, the vote shares of the parties will be known. Alliances may change. The BJP may attempt to break parties and gain MLAs – as it did in other States – even if the DMK gets a majority. In such a situation, I should not remain detached from

Tamil Nadu politics. We must remain vigilant 24/7 not just to protect our party but to safeguard social justice politics, State rights, and left-democratic politics in Tamil Nadu.

In your party, three MLAs were denied renomination. Why?

With only eight seats, there were many in the party eager to contest. If we get 25 seats, we can renominate the current MLAs and give an opportunity to new people. But with just eight seats, we retained four. Nearly 2,050 people applied for nomination. And around 370 people wanted me to contest. The workers want opportunities. This is a democratic reshuffle. There are no allegations or disciplinary reasons against those MLAs. We also considered representation – community, seniority, and women. This time,

we gave two seats to women. We have also accommodated senior-most comrades like Attral Arasu.

Do you still believe the DMK alliance, despite the inclusion of some caste-based or right-leaning groups, can claim to be the “ideological opposition” to the NDA?

The inclusion of one or two such parties does not dilute the alliance’s ideological identity. The Left parties and others firmly oppose right-wing politics. Some may have had past associations [like the Tamilar Desam Party], but they may evolve. Joining this alliance shows they are not strongly committed to right-wing ideology.

How do you view the criticism that the VCK has not effectively addressed caste atrocities and custodial deaths under DMK rule?

A government alone cannot transform everything in five years. Officials act based on their own mindset. Laws exist, but their implementation depends on individuals. A structural change requires time. We have conducted protests, mobilised thousands, met officials, gone to court. But beyond protests, solutions require greater political power. Caste and religious

structures continue unchanged. The officials’ caste mentality cannot be changed overnight. If an official has an anti-Dalit psyche or harbours hate for Muslims, nothing will change. We have discussed laws against honour-based crimes and reservation in promotions. The DMK has responded positively. We need to understand the issues within the system... It is not about AIADMK or DMK rule, but my point is that bureaucracy has an equal responsibility as the government.

How do you view actor Vijay’s decision not to ally with the BJP despite allegedly facing pressure from it?

His decision is welcome. But that alone does not mean he opposes the BJP. He has not criticised the BJP directly. His stance appears temporary, possibly to maintain his image.

Porkodi, widow of slain BSP leader Armstrong, has decided to contest from Thiru.Vi. Ka. Nagar on the AIADMK’s ‘Two Leaves’ symbol...

She needs protection. I appreciate she has boldly come out to be in public life. She also faces a threat to her life, and she needs some space in politics. If the AIADMK has given her that space, we welcome it.

These drum-beaters are a vital part of election campaigns



Drawing in the crowd: Chenda Melam players at a poll campaign in Chennai. They find work all through the year. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Sahana Mira S.
CHENNAI

Hours before an election campaign, the venue mostly resembles a festival. Groups of people assemble the stage, rig up speakers, and tie banana leaves and garlands to the arches of the entrance. The activity is conspicuous with the sound of drums piquing your curiosity.

By the entrance, Chenda Melam players were on one side. Adjacent to them was another set of percussion artistes, with drums blaring through the Mylapore neighbourhood long before AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami arrived to launch his campaign in the city recently.

“We start the work long before the campaigns start during the day to pull the crowd in. Our drum sounds reach people staying indoors and prompt them to come out and listen to the candidates,” said

Dhinesh Kumar, 23, from Ramanathapuram, who was performing Chenda Melam with three rows of artistes.

Some years ago, the election period was the peak season for these percussion artistes. They would look for other jobs thereafter. However, the drummers say the demand now is year-round. “We play for store openings, temples, functions, and events these days. During the election season, we are busier since we play for the campaign of any political party,” said Manikkam K., a drummer of another troupe at the venue. He hails from Ranipet, and has been in this field for the past 35 years.

Mr. Dhinesh Kumar said most of their regular events would happen either in the morning or in the evening. But political campaigns run throughout the day at different venues. So the team makes sure they are well prepared.

The demand for alternatives may have forced TVK to field bigwigs in some seats

Rationale behind TVK’s choice of select constituencies

A key functionary of the TVK says the seats in question have been found to be “favourable”, and there is “no need to take a narrow view” of its decision

Constituency	NTK		MNM during 2021 Assembly poll	BJP+ 2024 Lok Sabha poll	The sum of voteshares of NTK & MNM during 2021 Assembly poll	The sum of voteshares of NTK & BJP+ during 2024 Lok Sabha poll
	2021 Assembly poll	2024 Lok Sabha poll				
Perambur	9.89%	11.75%	8.52%	13.17%	18.41%	24.92%
Tiruchi East	8.28%	8.34%	6.59%	11%	14.87%	18.34%
T. Nagar	6%	5.15%	10.55%	36.40%	16.55%	41.55%
Villivakkam	9.27	7.71%	7.57%	21.17%	16.84%	28.88%
Mylapore	6.60%	6.54%	9.71%	28.09%	16.31%	34.63%

Putting up a fight: Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam leader C. Joseph Vijay started his State-wide political tour from the Tiruchi (East) Assembly constituency in September last year. M. MOORTHY



T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

The desire for an alternative to Tamil Nadu’s principal political forces – the ruling DMK and the AIADMK – among sizeable sections of society may be behind the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) fielding some of its top leaders in certain constituencies.

For the purpose of this study, the data regarding the vote shares of the Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK), both for the 2021 Assembly and 2024 Lok Sabha elections; the Makkal Needhi Maiam (MNM) in 2021; and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led front in 2024 have been taken into account.

The formation now

For this year’s Assembly election, the MNM has joined hands with the DMK, and the BJP and the Amma Makkal Munentra Kazhagam (AMMK) have aligned

In Perambur and Tiruchi (East), where TVK founder C. Joseph Vijay is contesting, the combined vote share of the NTK and the MNM in 2021 was 18.4% (Perambur) and nearly 14.9% (Tiruchi-East)

with the AIADMK. In Perambur and Tiruchi (East), where TVK founder C. Joseph Vijay is contesting, the combined vote share of the NTK and the MNM in 2021 was 18.4% (Perambur) and nearly 14.9% (Tiruchi-East).

The combined strength of the NTK and the BJP-led coalition rose to nearly 25% and 18.3% respectively three years later. In respect of Perambur and Tiruchi (East), the BJP and AMMK candidates were in the fray. Likewise, in the previous

Assembly election, in T. Nagar and Mylapore, which fall under the South Chennai Lok Sabha constituency, the MNM secured, five years ago, 10.55% and 9.7% of the votes polled totally.

Modest score

The NTK’s score was modest, with about 6% each in the two places. The sum of the two parties’ strength was around 16% each in these constituencies. During the Lok Sabha election, the presence of Tamilisai Soundararajan as the BJP nominee made a difference, as the national party’s vote share was 36% and 28% respectively.

As for the NTK, it broadly held on to its strength. As a result, the combined vote share was around 41.5% for T. Nagar and 34.6% for Mylapore.

Villivakkam, which comes under the Central Chennai Lok Sabha constituency, saw the two non-

DMK and non-AIADMK formations securing around 17% and 29% in those two elections.

Of the five seats, it was in Tiruchi (East) where non-DMK and non-AIADMK formations were not able to improve their performance considerably during the 2024 Lok Sabha election. In the remaining places, the combined vote share of the NTK and the NDA varied from nearly 25% in Perambur to 41.5% in T. Nagar.

‘Favourable seats’

However, a key functionary of the TVK dismisses the suggestion that the selection of constituencies for the high-profile candidates has been done with the factors of religion and caste composition kept in mind. The seats in question, in the assessment of the party, have been found to be “favourable”, and there is “no need to take a narrow view” of the decision.

INBRIEF



City hospital removes tumour from critical part of brain

A team of neurosurgeons at Gleneagles Hospital in Chennai has successfully removed a rare and complex tumour located in a critical area of the brain of a 30-year-old man diagnosed with a rare and newly-recognised aggressive brain tumour classified by the World Health Organization in 2021. It was located deep within a critical and surgically challenging area of the brain, very close to the brain stem and major blood vessels. The team of doctors, headed by Nigel Symss, senior consultant neurosurgeon, and Venkatesan Sanjeevi, senior consultant neurosurgeon, performed a two-stage surgical procedure that lasted approximately eight hours, and successfully removed the tumour without any complications.

Bottle pieces ‘hurled’ at TVK campaign meeting in city

Tension prevailed for a while as broken pieces of bottles were allegedly thrown from a high-rise building during an election campaign meeting of TVK candidate and party general secretary (election campaign management) Aadhav Arjuna at Villivakkam on Tuesday evening. Sources said the bottle pieces were allegedly thrown by unidentified persons from a nearby building when TVK functionary Nanjil Sambath was addressing the gathering. A bottle piece reportedly hit a woman, following which she was administered first aid, sources said. Mr. Arjuna, who was on the stage at the time, threatened to stage a sit-in protest if police did not take action against those responsible. He claimed that members of a rival political party were involved in the act. In a statement, party general secretary N. Anand condemned the incident. The police have detained one person in connection with the incident.

CONSTITUENCY WATCH

Deepa H. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Not much has happened in terms of development in the Chengalpattu Assembly Constituency over the last five years. Demands such as cleaning the Kolavai lake, completion of work to lay sewer lines, connecting the subway below the Chengalpattu rail over bridge, and provision of Palar River water to all areas, remain unfulfilled, say residents.

The constituency has been alternatively choosing candidates belonging to AIADMK and DMK. It has a considerable farming community that has been demanding check dams across the Palar River to improve ground water levels.

“We want a dam at Udayanpakkam. The government had sanctioned its construction, but it is yet to be constructed. It would help increase ground water level for residents, and help the sugarcane farmers of the area,” said R. Muralimohan, a resident. Check dams have been constructed at Pazhaya Seevaram, Vallipuram, and Eesur where water levels are better than other places. Residents have been demanding the construction of check

Chengalpattu

Residents in this constituency express disappointment over poor civic infrastructure development in the last five years

KEY ISSUES

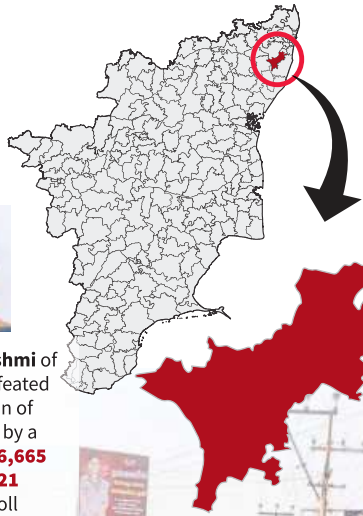
■ Chengalpattu GH needs adequate staff and more specialties

■ Kolavai Lake remains extremely polluted

■ Interior roads remain dug up, causing accidents



M. Varalakshmi of the DMK defeated M. Gajendran of the AIADMK by a margin of 26,665 votes in 2021 Assembly poll



Electors before SIR:
Total: 4,26,535
Men : 2,09,611
Women : 2,16,868
Others : 56

Electors after SIR:
Total: 3,66,400
Men : 1,78,076
Women : 1,88,267
Others : 57

Number of polling stations
496



Tough commute: Residents say traffic inside Chengalpattu town is chaotic, especially during weekends and festivals, as vehicles from the GST Road take the narrow interior roads. M. KARUNAKARAN

dams for every 5 km on the river.

'MSP promise unkept'

Parasuraman, a farmer, said that the government had promised a minimum

support price (MSP) of ₹5,000 per tonne. But that promise has not been kept. “We always get farm loans in a delayed manner and not when we really need it - during the sowing season.

There is unnecessary political influence at Aavin's milk procurement centres and at the direct procurement centres, which must be done away with. Lack of quality seeds

Police probing death of 15-year-old boy from Madhya Pradesh

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The police are probing the death of a 15-year-old boy from Madhya Pradesh (MP)

under suspicious circumstances.

The boy alleged that he was sexually assaulted by two unidentified men at Chennai Central Railway

Station in November 2025. He also got himself admitted to the Government Stanley Hospital. A case was registered under the Protection of Children

from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act.

A senior police officer said, “Our investigation clearly revealed that no sexual assault was commit-

ted as claimed by the boy. After treatment, the boy himself retracted his earlier version in his statement. His parents living in MP refused to take him.

Hence, he was lodged at a Home for Boys in Royapuram.” The boy, later, developed health complications and died without responding to treatment.

SIMATS’ national conclave on critical role of communication in modern healthcare concludes

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The National Conclave on Communication in Healthcare, organized by Saveetha Institute of Medical and Technical Sciences (SIMATS) in collaboration with the National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences (NBEMS), Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India, was successfully conducted on Monday at the MM Convention Centre, Saveetha Dental College.

The conclave emerged as a landmark academic event, bringing together leading experts, policy-makers, educators, and healthcare professionals from across the country to deliberate on the critical role of communication in modern healthcare.

The event witnessed overwhelming participation, with over 15 premier institutions and more than 1,500 delegates attending, reflecting the growing recognition of communication as a core competency in clinical practice. The conclave served as a vibrant platform for knowledge exchange, interdisciplinary dialogue, and capacity building, reinforcing the

Over 15 premier institutions and more than 1,500 delegates attended the conclave

importance of effective communication in ensuring patient safety, trust, and quality healthcare delivery.

The inaugural session commenced with the Presidential Address by N.M. Veeraiyan, Chancellor, Saveetha Institute of Medical and Technical Sciences (SIMATS), which set a visionary and inspiring tone for the conclave. In his address, he highlighted that while communication is often perceived as a soft skill, it is, in reality, a powerful clinical tool that directly influences patient outcomes.

He emphasised that words can heal, underscoring the profound impact of compassionate and empathetic communication in enhancing the healing process. He further stressed the need to integrate structured communication training across all levels of medical education in alignment with competency-based curricula.

This was followed by

the address of Abhijat C. Sheth, Chairman, National Medical Commission (NMC), Government of India, who emphasised the integration of communication skills within competency-based medical education and its direct impact on patient outcomes. The presence of distinguished leadership from NBEMS further elevated the academic stature of the conclave, including Minu Bajpai, Executive Director, NBEMS; Shishtha Nadda Basu, Member, Governing Body, NBEMS; and Shiva-kant Misra, Vice-President, NBEMS.

The scientific sessions featured an exceptional panel of experts including Sitangshu Basu, Rajesh Upadhyay, Veena Upadhyay, and Ajay Kumar. The sessions were highly engaging and practice-oriented, focusing on empathy in patient care, breaking bad news, non-verbal communication, and managing difficult conversations. Special emphasis was placed on addressing violence against healthcare professionals and the importance of structured communication in preventing conflict and improving workplace safety.

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MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

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THE MUSIC ACADEMY
5th APRIL Sunday 7pm
CRAZY MOHAN'S CHOCOLATE KRISHNA

Iravu' by S. Gowrishankar. 30th Koothapiran Navabharath theatres 'VEERA' by R. Vignesh. From 1st to 3rd May at MFAC Daily 7pm- 1st Ajay Entertainers' 'Kannamma' by D. Mallikaraj. 2nd Theatre Marina's 'Seyyadha Kolai' by Bombay Gnanam. 3rd Dummies Drama's 'ThanimAI' by Nithya Kaushik.

Narada Gana Sabha
Ph: 24993201
Programme April 26 - 2nd - Youth Concert in memory of Smt. Sulochana Sivakumar - Chharulatha Chandrareskhar (Veena), A Rohith (Mridangam), Hari Kishore (Kanjira), 8th Nadasangamam - Talent Promotion Concert - 5.30pm - Arvind Balaji, R Srikriti, G Prem Krishnan, 7 pm - Gayatri Mani, S Subhashree, Anirudh Raj. 13th - Music - In association with SB family - Veena Vidwan S.Bal-chander's 36th Anniversary- Abhishek Raghuram, H.N.Bhas-kar, Kishore Ramesh, S Krishna. 16th - Swathi Thirunal Day - Music - Kiran and Nivi (Sai Sisters) Gayathri Vibhavari, Sarvesh Karthik. 18th Main Hall - Drama UAA presents 'Varadhu Kutty' by Y Gee Mahendra. 18th - Mimi Hall - Natyarangam - Bharathanatyam 6 pm- Tony Pios (Disciple of Chitra Dasarathy). 7.30pm - Akhila Balasubramaniam (Disciple of Urmila Sathyannayanan)

Kartik Fine Arts
Ph: 24997788 / 9840928049
Programmes for April 2026, 3rd 7pm at MFAC- Dummies drama inaugurates 'Mr. Stranger' by V. Sreevathson. 14th 5.30pm at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan Main Auditorium, 51st Anniversary Celebrations- Award function. Presentation of Kartik Lifetime Achievement Awards & Kartik Awards of Excellence 2026, followed by Jhankaar Live - R.P. Shravan & Band - A Cine Carnatic Confluence. Kartik Ra-jagopal 35th Kodai Nataka Vizha 2026 at Narada Gana Sabha Main Hall from 22nd to 30th Daily 7pm 22nd Sathya Sai Cre-ations' 'Yamini En Kannmani' by Ezhichur Aravindan. 23rd Brahma Fine Arts' 'Maya Sangili' by K. Prakash. 24th JC Creations' 'Madhil Mel Poonnigal' by V.P.S. Sriraman. 25th Legally Yours' 'Kudumbadang' by Satish Chandrasekara. 26th 'Kalai Il-anani S. Sruthi's Naatya Naadha Nataka- Sangamam's 'Kandhan Karunai' by S. Thyagu. 27th PMG Mayurapriya's 'Kallabiramam' by P. Muthuku-maran. 28th Prasadidhi Cre-ations' 'Yagavarayinum' by Ambi Raghavan. 29th Theatrx Stage Crafters' 'Mazhaiyil Oor

Rasika Rangini Sabha Foundation
Mylapore, Chennai - 600 004.
Programme for the month of APRIL - 2026
15.04.2026 - Wednesday
5.00 pm - Prajna Adiga & Party - Vocal
6.30 pm - Prarthana Sai Narasimhan & Party - Vocal
17.04.2026 - Friday
6.30 pm - UAA in its 74th Year
Y Gee Mahendra in & as Varadukutty Paritchaikku Neramachu - 2 (Drama)
21.04.2026 - Tuesday
5.00 pm - Arvind Balaji & Party - Vocal
6.30 pm - New Years of Bharat
Talk by MADHUSUDANAN KALAIELVAN
Music by SAI VIGNESH & Party - Vocal
Ph. No: 86103 57987
All Rasikas Are Welcome

The Mylapore Fine Arts Club (Regd.)
Phone: 24997755/42607755
75th Year - Program for April 04/04/2026 6.45pm Dummies Drama Mr.Stranger 18/04/2026 6.45pm Dance Drama EKADASA VISHNUM by Dr.Sheela Un-nikrishnan 19/04/2026 5.45 & 7.15pm Bharathanatyam by Stu-dents of Bhavani Natyalaya

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INBRIEF



Tamilselvan receives Sahitya Akademi award in Delhi

Writer S. Tamilselvan received the Sahitya Akademi Award for 2025 at a function in Delhi. His work *Tamil Sirukathaiyin Thadangal* won the award in the category of literary criticism. The book traces the history of the Tamil short story, offering critical insights beginning with V.V.S. Iyer's *Kulathankarai Arasamaram*, widely regarded as the first short story in Tamil. Su. Venkatesan, CPI(M) MP and a Sahitya Akademi Award winner for his novel *Kaval Kottam*, congratulated him on receiving the honour.

Group led by PwD moves to register as political party

A newly formed organisation, *Matruthiranaligal Munnetra Kazhagam*, led by persons with disabilities (PwD) from Tamil Nadu, has initiated steps to become a political party by applying for registration with the Election Commission of India (ECI). “We may not be able to contest in the upcoming Assembly election, but we will definitely contest in the future. We have always lived on the margins of society,” said Samuel Raj, president of *Matruthiranaligal Munnetra Kazhagam*, from Madurai, at a press meet held in the city. Mr. Raj said that persons with disabilities do not seek concessions or monthly stipends, which he noted as insufficient. Instead, he said that employment opportunities are needed. “We are graduates but still many persons with disabilities still do not have access to jobs. We are often treated as rejected members of society,” he said. The party was formed because many other sections of society lacked adequate political attention and representation. “The political party has been formed to bring about a change so that these voices are heard,” Mr. Raj said.

Four persons convicted in fake vegetable business scam after 18 years

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

After nearly 18 years of trial, the XI Metropolitan Magistrate Court in Saidapet convicted four persons on Monday of duping several investors by promising high returns from a non-existent vegetable trade, and sentenced them to undergo four years imprisonment.

The case was registered in 2008 at the Mylapore police station based on a complaint lodged by M. Kalpana, 29, a resident of Mylapore.

Police booked four accused under Sections 120(B) (criminal conspiracy) read with 420 (cheating) of the Indian Penal Code.

According to the prosecution, the complainant had come into contact with the accused through insurance-related transactions. The accused allegedly lured her, and several others across Chennai and nearby districts, to invest large sums of money in a purported vegetable business, assuring lucrative profits. However, the business was found to be non-existent.

Given the scale of the fraud, the case was later transferred to the CB-CID by the Madras High Court. During investigation, more victims lodged complaints.

The accused were arrested in 2009, but the trial proceedings were prolonged due to repeated delays and their failure to appear in court on multiple occasions.

The court convicted all the accused — R. Anuradha of Tiruchi, A. Mohammed Ali Jinna of Urapakkam, M. Mustafa of Maduravoyal, and K. Ravichandran.

New fuel from CSIR-NCL Pune has a Tamil connect

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

As the country looks for alternative fuel sources amidst the West Asia crisis, a team of scientists of the CSIR - National Chemical Laboratory (NCL) in Pune, led by Chief Scientist Raja Thirumalaiswamy, a Tamil from Bhavani, is getting ready to transfer the technology for a reactor and catalyst that will produce Dimethyl Ether (DME), that can be used as an alternative to Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG).

“Already, seven companies and three countries, including Finland and Ghana, have approached us for this technology on which we have been working since 2016. We started producing 500 mg, and we have now scaled up to 2500 kg/day. ONGC has



Chief Scientist of CSIR-NCL, Pune, Raja Thirumalaiswamy with his team. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

tied up with us for producing 2.5 tonnes/day at its facility at Hazira. We have five patents for the indirect method of deriving DME from methanol. Our catalyst works in lower temperatures and is better in terms of purity and opera-

tional costs,” Dr. Thirumalaiswamy explained.

DME with LPG
The process has been certified with due diligence from IOCL Research and Development, Faridabad; Attrium

Innovations, Pune; and ONGC, New Delhi.

“We got the patent for our catalyst in 2019. It is very strong and will not crumble easily. It works at 10 bar pressure. We have designed cooking stoves that work with both LPG and DME. Though DME is heavier than air and will sink, we have designed it in such a manner that the flame will burn upwards. Ordinary household stoves usually work with 64% to 68% efficiency. Ours work with an efficiency of 74.5%. Regular stoves can use up to 20% DME blended with LPG without making any major changes except for a seal,” he explained.

The catalyst, which is the key to their variant of DME, has been on trial for over 15,000 hours with scientists, including Mani-

kandan, Sivaprasad, Akash Bhatkar, Samruddhi Mane, and Praveen, continuously monitoring it. “Our catalyst can withstand sulphur that comes from gasification of coal up to a certain extent,” he added.

Mr. Raja has been working on various other technologies like Biodiesel production from vegetable oil; Methane reforming technologies for hydrogen production; CO2 conversion to Methanol; Shale gas utilisation etc. These technologies are a few of his important research contributions and patents where the concentration was deeply towards the converting the green house gases to value added products. Mostly his research group dedicated to valorisation of C1 chemistry.

Residents complain about rise in stray dog bite incidents in several areas

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

Residents have complained about a rise in dog bite incidents in the city.

Ward 191 resident Sowmya of Jalladianpet said residents have complained about repeated dog bite incidents in her neighbourhood.

“Another dog bite incident occurred yesterday in our area. A pedestrian was bitten by a stray dog and had to be taken to the hospital. Although we could not identify the individual or trace the dog, immediate help from local residents ensured that the situation was handled promptly. This is not an isolated occurrence, and the repeated nature of

such incidents is causing serious concern among residents,” she said.

“Authorities should take strict and effective measures to address the issue, like controlling the stray dog population, taking necessary action to remove aggressive dogs, and installing clear signage indicating designated feeding and non-feeding zones. Unregulated feeding of stray dogs across all areas has contributed to an increase in their numbers, which is now posing a risk to pedestrians, especially children,” she said.

At Saidapet Metrorail station, several dogs are being fed every night by different groups of people at various entry and exit points of the station.

The personnel manning the parking lots say they keep telling those feeding the strays not to do so, but they continue to feed them every night.

Purva Windermere Apartments Owners Association held a meeting recently to discuss the rise in number of dog bite incidents. Residents reported 39 dog bite cases, mostly involving children and senior citizens.

Anna Nagar resident Kali Doss said the residents have complained about dog bite incidents in the neighbourhood of CPWD quarters. “Students are scared,” he said. Corporation officials said the city has not registered any rabies cases in the past three

months. Over 25,000 dog bite incidents were reported in the city last year. One person died of rabies in Royapettah in Teynampet zone last year.

“Measures for sterilisation and control of the dog population will be taken up to reduce the number of dog bite cases. We have increased the number of pet clinics from five to ten this year. As a result, the number of sterilisations carried out per month has increased from 1,500 to 3,000 dogs. Once the ABC centres and pet clinics are launched in Alandur, Sholinganallur, Ambattur and Perungudi, the number GCC will achieve sterilisation of 4,500 dogs per month,” said an official.

THE HINDU
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ELECTRICAL WORKS UNDER TINSUKIA DIVISION

E-Tender Notice No. TSK/Elect/ 232; dated: 27-03-2026. Works tender through E-Tendering System are invited by the undersigned for the following works: **SN.1. Brief Description of Item:** Provision and augmentation of 750 Volt Supply arrangement for maintenance of HOG coaches in washing/sick lines at Dibrugarh Coaching depot. (Tender No. LV-T-14-TSK-921-R-1). Tender Value: ₹92,47,546.92; Earnest Money: ₹1,85,000.00. **SN.2. Brief Description of Item:** Provision of Earthing and RCCB in Electrical Installation & APFC Panels in Identified Load Centres. (Tender No. LV-T-14-TSK-924-R). Tender Value: ₹1,40,68,185.00; Earnest Money: ₹2,20,400.00. **E-tenders will be closed at 13:00 hrs. on 20-04-2026 and Opened at 15:00 hrs. on 20-04-2026.** The complete information with the tender document of above e-tender will be available upto **13:00 hrs on 20-04-2026** in website <http://www.iirps.gov.in>

DRM (Elect.)/Tinsukia NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY "Serving Customers with a smile"



For smooth ride: The 13.5-km, four-lane corridor will take a little over three years to be built. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Soil tests begin for proposed elevated corridor on ECR

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Driving by Injambakkam on the East Coast Road recently, you might have noticed barricades on the median. These are temporary barricades placed for the ongoing soil tests by the contractor constructing the ₹2,100-crore 13.5-km long four-lane wide Thiruvannmiyur-Uthandi elevated corridor.

The tests will be conducted over the next few months at a total of 430 points where pillars of the elevated corridor will come up. “We will pick up samples of soil and see at what depth we hit different layers of sand, clay, soft rock, and hard rock for up to 25 metres. These will be sent to our design department, which will design the foundation and other structures according to the soil layers,” explained an engineer associated with the project.

Each soil test point will have drilling machines placed inside a 2.5 mt x 2.5 mt enclosure and a hole that will be 100 mm diameter. Each location will take about two to three days to complete drilling and then restoring the place with cement concrete. At present, six drills are working in the two-km stretch. The number of drilling machines is expected to go up to 30 at a time in a phased manner, explained another source.

Though soil tests were conducted when the studies for the detailed project report were being held, the contracting firm will still conduct its own set of soil tests to be doubly sure as it concerns the stability of the structure. The corridor will take a little over three years to be completed and will allow motorists to drive without stopping for tens of junctions on the road. There are over 130 side roads that join the ECR in that stretch.

Chennai Weather max min
Tiruvallur 36 23
Chennai Airport 34 26
Chennai City 33 26

Chennai Airport Today
36°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be very warm. Night will also be comfortable. Mostly dry weather to prevail.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
35°C The weather will be warm. Spell of light rain and thundershowers with gusty winds to occur. Night will be comfortable.

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Timings CHENNAI

WEDNESDAY, APR. 01
RISE 06:06 SET 18:21
RISE 17:49 SET 05:22

THURSDAY, APR. 02
RISE 06:05 SET 18:21
RISE 18:37 SET 05:58

FRIDAY, APR. 03
RISE 06:04 SET 18:21
RISE 19:26 SET 06:35

Punjab State Grains Procurement Corporation Limited (PUNGRAIN)
Anaaaj Bhawan, Sector-39, Chandigarh
Email: foodpurchase.fcs@punjab.gov.in

Notice Inviting Tender
E-Tender for Procurement of Unique QR Tag Stitchable on Bags
Pungrain invites online tender under two-bid system for supply of purchase of Unique QR Tag Stitchable on Bags.

The bid/tender document and other details are available on the e-procurement portal of the Government of Punjab i.e. <http://eproc.punjab.gov.in> and <http://foodsupp.pb.gov.in>.

Bid Submission Start Date : From 01.04.2026
Bid Submission Last Date : 10.04.2026

Note: Pungrain reserves the right to cancel the tender at any stage without assigning any reason and Pungrain will not be held liable for any cost and consequences incurred by the intending bidders.

Any corrigendum / addendum will be uploaded on GeM portal.

1027/12/2025-26/10064 Managing Director Pungrain

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

Dr. Er. M. R. Chandrasekaran, PhD. (88)
Yoga Guru, President, BVS, TN Chapter
Attained Mukti on 31-03-2026
Last rites 1pm today at his residence.
No. 24/33 Nathamuni Street, T. Nagar, Chennai-600017
Mourning by beloved
Sons, Daughter, Daughters-in-Law, Son-in-Law, Grandkids and numerous disciples, yoga students

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

24th ANNIVERSARY
Sangeetha Kalanidhi Sri. Paighat
Prof. K.V. Narayanaswamy
16.11.1923 ✶ 01.04.2002
Wife: Mrs. Padma Narayanaswamy

DEATH

In Loving memory
SORNAMANI S A
DOB: 09th March 1959
DOD: 31st March 2026
Director -
eNtrust Software & Services Pvt Ltd
You will be remembered for your kindness, love and beautiful memories forever remain in our hearts.
Deeply mourned by
Staff, Friends and Family

Survey on for last-mile connectivity routes around Metro Rail stations

The MTC is in the process of buying over 200 buses that will serve as shuttle services to and from the stations in the 54-km Phase I network. The facility may be rolled out later this year; commuters can use the Singara Chennai card to pay the fare

TRACK TALES

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

Chennai Metro Rail has been carrying out a survey to finalise the routes to operate feeder buses that will serve as a last mile connectivity in and around major stations.

The Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) has been in the process of procuring 220 buses which serve as shuttle services to pick up and drop off commuters from Chennai Metro Rail stations for the 54-km Phase I network. This facility is expected to be rolled out later this year.

When implemented, like in Singapore, when you hop onto Chennai Metro Rail's feeder buses later this year, you can just



Faster mobility: Chennai Unified Metropolitan Transport Authority flagged the need to enhance connectivity in and around Metro Rail stations in the Comprehensive Mobility Plan. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

swipe your Singara Chennai card or pay through your mobile. These shuttle buses, which will zip around the station neighbourhoods, will operate cashless and without a conductor as well.

Of the 220 buses, 150 buses will have a capacity

to accommodate 11 passengers plus a driver, and the remaining 70 buses, 16 passengers and a driver. These buses will cover stations, including Koyambedu, Thirumangalam, Chennai airport, Meenambakkam, Nanganallur, Wimco Nagar, Ashok Nagar, Saida-

pet, and Little Mount. Though 22 mini buses ply from some of these stations, additional buses will be operated under this new scheme too.

Chennai Unified Metropolitan Transport Authority (CUMTA) has flagged the need to enhance last-mile connectivity in and around Metro Rail stations in the Comprehensive Mobility Plan, and pointed out how it would boost patronage and has also done a study on it.

Officials of Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL) said that since high demand exists in these stations, more buses are added here. The study has been under way for a few weeks and the plan is to cover nearly 2,000 commuters. "We want to operate these shuttle services for commuters. Hence, it makes sense to get commu-

ter opinions before starting them. Through the survey, we want to understand from which areas people travel to stations and how they commute to these stations. We plan to cover nearly 2,000 people in the survey. We are looking at a model wherein these buses glide residential areas as well which will be of convenience to commuters," an official said.

CMRL has been looking to cover a six km radius on which these buses will ply. But for Chennai airport Metro Rail station alone, the feeder services are likely to operate for an 8 km radius. Four depots will be set up for operating these last mile connectivity services. "The depot will come up at Koyambedu, Saidapet, Pallavaram, and Wimco Nagar. The land has already been identified," an official said.

PWD begins work on EVM warehouses in six district headquarters

K. Lakshmi
CHENNAI

The PWD has started constructing warehouses in six district headquarters to store electronic voting machines (EVMs) and voter verified paper audit trails (VVPATs). It has also initiated preliminary work for poll arrangements, including for counting centres and polling booths across the State, ahead of the Assembly election.

While the department has already built such warehouses in 31 district headquarters in 2021, it has started ₹36.39-crore project in districts, where new district administration buildings were recently constructed. The buildings are being constructed on the premises of the Collectorates in Ranipet, Kallakurichi, Tirupattur, Tenkasi, Chengalpattu, and Mayiladuthurai districts..

PWD officials said some warehouses, such as the ones in Chengalpattu and

Ranipet, would be single-storeyed structures with facilities, including closed-circuit television camera surveillance. Each structure has been designed based on the number of EVMs and VVPATs to be stored. While rooms have been designed without windows to store EVMs, measures would be taken to provide sufficient ventilation.

The department is also carrying out preliminary work to set up counting halls and strongrooms at educational institutions across the State under its control. The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) will manage the counting halls in Chennai. Officials said work would begin in a few days. The strongrooms are designed to accommodate the entire number of EVMs in the same place in coordination with the district election officer. Besides dismantling the partitions, windows would be sealed for security.

Election team replaced by Tirupattur RO

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUPATTUR

The Revenue Divisional Officer (RDO) and Returning Officer (RO) for Tirupattur Assembly constituency S. Varadharajan on Tuesday has replaced a four-member Flying Squad Team (FST) with a new team after the former was caught sleeping on election duty.

Viral on social media
Election officials said that the FST members were relieved of their election duties, after the video of them sleeping in a transport vehicle at Kunichi village near town went viral on social media.

The order to relieve the FST of their election duties followed a direction by Collector and District Election Officer (DEO), K. Sivasundaravalli. "The said FST members, who were relieved of election duties, were asked to return to their original government departments to resume work there," Mr. Varadharajan told *The Hindu*.

THE HINDU OPPORTUNITIES

Over 120 Jobs in today's issue

GENERAL



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Kristu Jayanti (Deemed to be University), K. Narayana-pura, Kothanur P.O., Bengaluru-560 077, Karnataka, India. **Tel: 080-68737777 career@kristujayanti.com**

**MSEZ Authority,**
Office of the Development Commissioner
MEPZ Special Economic Zone,
GST Road, Tambaram, Chennai - 600 045
Advt.No. F.No.01/01/2023/ MSEZA Date: 20.03.2026

EMPLOYMENT NOTICE
Applications are invited from eligible and interested candidates for engagement in the Office of the Development Commissioner, MEPZ Special Economic Zone Authority, on a contractual basis, for the following positions:

Sl. No.	Name of the post	No. of Vacancies
1)	Facility & Security Officer	1
2)	Marketing Consultant	1
3)	Young Professional	12
4)	Internship Trainee	4
5)	Programme Manager	1

★ The number of vacancies indicated is provisional and may be increased or decreased by MEPZ SEZ Authority depending upon the actual requirements at the time of selection.

★ The eligibility criteria, qualifications, experience, tenure of engagement and remuneration for the above posts shall be as per the terms and conditions specified in the detailed advertisement.

★ Interested candidates may visit the official website www.mepz.gov.in for complete details and the application procedure.

★ The last date for submission of applications is 15 days from the date of publication of this advertisement. However, for the post of Young Professional, the last date for submission of applications shall be 90 days from the date of publication

★ The MEPZ SEZ Authority reserves the right to accept or reject any or all applications without assigning any reason.

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RECRUITMENT NOTIFICATION
PMIST/Advt./Recruit/001/2026
dated: 01.04.2026
Applications are invited for the following posts
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• Qualification & Experience as per AICTE / UGC / NCTE norms.
• Retired Professors below 62 years can also apply.

Eligible candidates may apply with their Resume on or before 16.04.2026 through <https://pmu.edu/careerportal/>

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Yamnampet, Ghatkesar, Hyderabad – 501 302

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• Bachelors in Business Administration (Business Analytics, Business Statistics, Business Communication, Finance, Economics, Accounting, Marketing, Supply Chain Management, Organisational Behaviour, Information Systems, AI & HR Management)
 - Technical Trainers:** C, C++, Java, Python, Full stack Developer, Database, JavaScript, Coding Platforms awareness, Data Structure Algorithm, Problem Solving, Generative & Agentie AI.
 - Teaching Assistant / Lab Assistants:** CSE, Physics & English
- Interested candidates can please send your CV to careers@suh.edu.in
Applications must be received within 10 days from the date of this advertisement.
Landline Number: +91-9133386676 (9:30 am – 4:30 pm; Monday - Friday).

Approved by the Government of Telangana G.O.Ms.No.55 dated 30th July, 2024.

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Sl. No.	Post	Qualification	No. of posts & Reservation	Experience as on 01.04.2026
1	Field Operations Engineer	B.E/B.Tech in E&C	6 Posts 3 UR 2 OBC (NCL) 1 EWS	7 Years
2		B.E/B.Tech in Mechanical		

For detailed advertisement please visit "Recruitments" section in our website www.bel-india.in.

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(Under the aegis of ICSSR, MoE, Govt)
Hyderabad

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- Banking & Fintech
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- International Business

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Tamil Nadu

INBRIEF



Flying squad inspects Stalin's vehicle on its way to Tiruvarur

The flying squad posted at Saliamangalam junction on Tiruchi-Nagapattinam Highway searched the vehicle in which DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin was travelling to Tiruvarur on Tuesday. Mr. Stalin landed at the Thanjavur Air Force Station in a private aircraft earlier in the day. His vehicle was intercepted by the team on the highway around 10.30 a.m. The team boarded the vehicle and checked the baggage of the Chief Minister, as well as the dashboard. Mr. Stalin's convoy continued its journey toward Tiruvarur after the check, sources said.

I-T officials search house of DMK functionary in Karur

Income Tax (I-T) officials on Tuesday carried out a search at the house of a DMK functionary at Kuppuchipalayam in Karur. Acting on a tip-off that gifts meant for distribution to voters were being kept in a house, a group of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) were posted around the residence of R. Ramasamy, 47, a DMK member and the area's ward secretary, on Monday night. However, the search was only conducted the next day. No one was allowed to leave the house during the night. According to sources, a group of five I-T officials, led by a Deputy Director, arrived at the spot in the morning and began the search around 7.30 a.m. They searched the house to check whether any gifts for voters were stocked there. They held inquiries with the occupants of the house. Mr. Ramasamy was present when the search was carried out. The checks went on for about two hours. Mr. Ramasamy told *The Hindu* that he had cooperated with the I-T officials and that they inquired whether he was in possession of any gifts meant for voters. They had not seized any articles from the house, he added.

Boycott NDA to protect the rights of T.N., says CM Stalin

Accusing Edappadi K. Palaniswami of becoming a branch secretary of the BJP, he asserts that the NDA has to be uprooted completely to prevent Tamil Nadu from becoming a land of violence

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUVARUR

DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Tuesday launched his campaign for the Assembly election from Tiruvarur by calling upon the people of Tamil Nadu to boycott the [AIADMK-led] National Democratic Alliance and rise above political differences to support the DMK-led alliance "to protect the rights of the State".

"We will surpass our achievements in the Dravidan Model 2.0 government and take Tamil Nadu to even greater heights. On the day of voting, you only need to decide whether you want the anti-Tamil, opportunistic NDA or the continuation of the achievements of the DMK government," he told the electorate, addressing a rally in Tiruvarur, which "shaped" his father and former Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi.

Coming down strongly on the BJP for denying funds and projects for Tamil Nadu, Mr. Stalin said the only objective of the NDA was to stop the development of Tamil Nadu and destroy the achievements of the DMK government.

According to him, the BJP has done nothing good for Tamil Nadu since it came to power at the Centre. No special scheme was sanctioned for the State, and funds were de-



Off to a start: Chief Minister M.K. Stalin and Minister T.R.B. Rajaa with the other candidates of the Secular Progressive Alliance at a public meeting in Tiruvarur on Tuesday. R. VENGADESH

nied even for drinking water supply schemes. "Despite the obstructions, we have made Tamil Nadu the Number 1 State through efficient administration. As we resisted Hindi imposition, we were denied funds for education too. Can we hand over the State to such a treacherous group?" he asked.

The Chief Minister said in order to protect Tamil Nadu, the DMK should return to power; if the State was to continue its march on the path of development, the DMK government should continue. "You know how opportunistic the NDA is. The AIADMK has surrendered to the BJP and its general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami has become a branch secretary of the BJP," he charged.

"The NDA has to be uprooted completely to prevent Tamil Nadu from becoming a land of violence. You should understand that we are fighting not only for the victory of DMK and its allies but also for the victory of Tamil Nadu," Mr. Stalin asserted, and "as a son of the soil", he called upon the people to rise above political differences to support the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance in the election.

Highlighting the salient features, including the "visionary schemes" for the delta region, of the party's "superstar" election manifesto, Mr. Stalin said they were not mere assurances. "We will definitely implement them," he said, seeking votes in support of the DMK candidates Poondi K. Kalaivanan (Tiruvarur) and

T.R.B. Rajaa (Mannargudi), K. Marimuthu (Thiruthurai-raipoondi) of the CPI and Mohammed Mubarak (Nannilam) of the SDPI.

Earlier in the day, Mr. Stalin visited his grandmother, Anjugam's memorial at Kattur near Tiruvarur and also paid a visit to the "Kalaingar Kottam," in the village, where he garlanded Karunanidhi's statue at the memorial.

Interestingly, the DMK president had launched his election campaigns for the 2019 Lok Sabha and the 2021 Assembly elections from Tiruvarur. While he launched the campaign on the town's outskirts in 2019, his 2021 Assembly election campaign began near the Kamalalayam tank, where he launched the campaign on Tuesday as well.

'Vijay does not have an understanding of the State's politics'

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

BJP's election in-charge for Tamil Nadu and Union Minister for Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal said on Tuesday that Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) president C. Joseph Vijay had no understanding of the people of Tamil Nadu, their culture, and politics.

Speaking to reporters at the Chennai airport, Mr. Goyal said many film stars had come [into politics] in the past and the people of Tamil Nadu had rejected them. "MGR [M.G. Ramachandran] and Jayalalithaa ji were experienced politicians, and after many years of serving the people, they became Chief Ministers. I think he [Mr. Vijay] is living in a dream. He is very popular among his fans. But that popularity will not result in votes, as we saw in the case of Vijayakant and Kamal Haasan."

Mr. Goyal said Mr. Vijay's political entry was "one more effort which will probably give him a few votes." He said he does not think the TVK would even cross three or four seats in Tamil Nadu. Highlighting DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin's repeated assertion that the upcoming election is a fight between Tamil Nadu and Delhi, the Minister quipped it was evident from the fight between the DMK and the Congress.

He said the seat-sharing among the constituents of the AIADMK-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) was smoothly worked out.



Piyush Goyal

"Two corrupt parties, the DMK and the Congress, joining hands and coming together is not what the people of Tamil Nadu want. The people want Prime Minister Narendra Modi's government at the Centre and Edappadi K. Palaniswami's government in the State. Such a double-engine government will bring double welfare and double good governance to the people of Tamil Nadu," he added.

Later, at Kamalalayam, the BJP's headquarters in Chennai, Mr. Goyal and senior party leaders, released a "chargesheet" against the Mr. Stalin-led DMK government. He said the BJP was shocked to see the increase in the number of sexual harassment cases against women and cases registered under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act in the last five years. He also alleged that some DMK councillors and youth wing functionaries were accused of sexual assault. Yet, the DMK had not taken action against them, he said.

CPI's manifesto promises to fight commercialisation of agriculture

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Assembly election manifesto released by the State unit of the Communist Party of India (CPI) in Chennai on Tuesday accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) of threatening political parties and forcing alliances on them ahead of the election.

M. Veerapandian, CPI State secretary, who released the manifesto, said even though the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) was reiterating that a government would be formed under its leadership, the BJP was asserting that the NDA would form the government. "The AIADMK has given up all its ideological moorings and merged itself with the BJP," he al-



M. Veerapandian, CPI State secretary, releasing the party's poll manifesto in Chennai on Tuesday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

leged. The CPI said it would ensure the development of micro, small, and medium industries and prevent the commercialisation of drinking water, agriculture, and irrigation. "We will ensure safe drinking water, protect the environment, uphold social justice, and safeguard the

Tamil language and culture," the manifesto said.

The party said it would set up drug and alcohol de-addiction centres. "We will not allow the implementation of the Citizenship Amendment Act and the National Register of Citizens in Tamil Nadu," the manifesto added.

The Hindu Bureau
SIVAKASI

Within three months of returning to power, the AIADMK government will eradicate ganja from the State, party general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami said on Tuesday.

He was addressing an election rally in Sivakasi, seeking votes for five AIADMK candidates and two BJP candidates in Virudhunagar district.

Mr. Palaniswami alleged that no place in Tamil Nadu was free from narcotic drugs. "Ganja is available in different forms – such as chocolate, tablets, and liquid. The lives of the members of the public, including school and college students addicted to ganja, are being ruined," he said.



Campaign mode: AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami speaking at a roadshow in Sivakasi on Tuesday. G. MOORTHY

He added that he had raised the issue of drug abuse in the Assembly several times. "Children are our future. We see their lives being ruined, and to stop these evils, the AIADMK must return to power in Tamil Nadu," he said.

Reiterating his promise, Mr. Palaniswami said ganja sales would be eradicated within three months if the AIADMK returned to power. "The AIADMK government will ensure that ganja is not available anywhere," he said.

Without naming any of

ficers, the Leader of the Opposition criticised the police, saying that a Director-General of Police had announced multiple anti-drug operations.

"However, he retired without eradicating ganja. This is because peddling was carried out by supporters of the ruling party," he alleged.

'Police failed miserably' He further claimed that the police had "miserably failed" to control the situation. "Even the police have no protection against drug addicts. In fact, addicts even assault police personnel," he said.

Mr. Palaniswami described the State Assembly election as an opportunity to put an end to such issues. He also alleged that

sexual assaults on women and children were on the rise under the DMK regime. Displaying a T-shirt that he said was given to him by girl children in Sivakasi, he claimed it carried a message expressing concern over their safety. "Only the AIADMK can ensure our safety. We do not want DMK rule any more," it read.

AIADMK candidates K.T. Rajenthra Bhalaji (Sivakasi), M. Chandra Prabha (Srivilliputtur), S. Sethupathi (Aruppukottai), M.S.R. Rajavarman (Tiruchuli), and V.G. Ganesan (Virudhunagar), along with BJP candidate Priscilla Pandian (Rajapalayam), were present.

Mr. Palaniswami also campaigned in Aruppukottai in the district.

Complaint lodged against Vijay, TVK cadre for roadshow violating poll code in Perambur

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A complaint has been lodged against Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) leader C. Joseph Vijay and his party cadre for conducting his election campaign in Perambur in a manner causing inconvenience to the public.

The complaint was filed at the Peravallur police station of the Greater Chennai Police by V. Kumar, an officer in-charge of the Static Surveillance Team of the Kolathur Assembly constituency.

The complainant stated that on Monday, while he



Choked stretch: The crowd at TVK president C. Joseph Vijay's election campaign in Perambur on Monday. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

was on duty at SRP Koil South Street near the Peravallur junction, around 3,000 members belonging

to the TVK gathered on the road holding party flags and causing obstruction to the public and vehicular

traffic. Around 3.40 p.m., Mr. Vijay arrived in a campaign vehicle along with others. Subsequently, around 5,000 party cadre assembled, blocking the movement of the public and ambulances and other vehicles.

Public disturbance

About 30 loudspeakers were installed on the roadside, and slogans of the TVK were raised at high volumes while Mr. Vijay carried out election campaigning until 3.45 pm. A roadshow was also conducted, further disrupting traffic, the complainant said.

The officer said permission was granted to the TVK to conduct election campaigning only between 5 p.m. and 6 p.m., with a maximum of 500 participants and the use of five sound systems.

However, violating these election norms, the gathering took place much earlier, around 3.40 p.m., under the leadership of Mr. Vijay, with nearly 5,000 people and 30 sound systems, causing disturbance to the public and traffic. The complainant has requested legal action against those responsible. Police sources said no case has been registered so far.

Police launch search for Class X boy involved in murder in Theni

The Hindu Bureau
THENI

A Class X student, allegedly figuring in a gruesome murder, reportedly absconded with a few of his friends and relatives in Chinnamanur in Theni district on Tuesday.

Police said Surya, 28, a daily wage earner, was murdered by a gang, that included the Class X boy.

Fatal attack

It is said that Surya scolded the teenaged boy for talking with his sister, who was also studying in the same school.

Irked by the way Surya shouted at him, the boy

complained to some of his friends and relatives, who attacked Surya with deadly weapons. This resulted in his death on Sunday night. The body was sent to the government hospital for a post-mortem examination.

Protest held

Since "there was no tangible action by the police", the relatives of the victim resorted to a road blockade on Tuesday. They squatted on the busy Chinnamanur-Cumbum highway.

The police said traffic was diverted for over two hours.

Uthamapalayam RDO Syed Mohamed and senior

police officers held talks with the protesters.

Probe on

The police said they were on the lookout for two suspects and also assured them of stern action. Following this, the protesters dispersed.

They also demanded action against the school authorities for not taking action against the boy despite being aware of the issue.

"They could have prevented this much earlier. Now, we have lost our breadwinner. Surya was just 28-years-old, married and has left behind two girl children," they said.



Unexpected surge

The Index of Industrial Production diverges from previous data

India’s industrial growth held a positive surprise in February 2026, coming in at 5.2%, marginally faster than the growth in January. Apart from November and December last year, February’s industrial performance – as measured by the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) – was the best in nearly two years. Why this was a surprise was because this performance diverges quite sharply from what was indicated by the Index of Eight Core Industries released earlier this month. The eight core sectors – crude oil, natural gas, refinery products, coal, fertilizers, steel, cement, and electricity – saw their combined growth slow to 2.3% in February, about half the growth rate in January. These core sectors have a weightage of about 40% in the IIP, and so the expectation was that they would drag the IIP down too. Yet, something else happened. This would imply that sectors outside the core ones did well. Most notably, the manufacturing sector in the IIP saw growth accelerate to a respectable 6% in February. The capital goods sector’s growth accelerated to a 28-month high of 12.5%, on an already strong base of 8.1%. These are good signs for labour and capital. What is more concerning is that some elements of consumer demand are going in the opposite direction. Consumer durables grew 7.3%, but consumer non-durables contracted 0.6%, the second consecutive month of shrinkage. It had contracted in February last year as well, so this was not a statistical anomaly.

In general, spending on non-durables involves greater discretion on a day-to-day basis, and so is a better gauge of consumer sentiment. At the moment, at least this data suggest that sentiment is low. This also correlates with the new series of national accounts data showing that household expenditure has had a shrinking contribution to GDP. The government should also look into why the IIP and the Eight Core Industries index moved in opposite directions in February. The two are normally highly correlated, and so a divergence is immediately noteworthy. From the looks of things, February’s strong IIP performance is likely to be a short-lived acceleration. The West Asia crisis is already having an impact on the economy. The monthly economic review by the Finance Ministry has said that early high-frequency economic indicators for March are pointing towards a “moderation in economic momentum”. The longer the war persists, the sharper this “moderation” is likely to be. On a positive note, while what is being measured might turn dismal, how it is being measured will soon improve. The new, upgraded series of IIP data will be released in May. As the new GDP and CPI have done, the new IIP is sure to provide a clearer picture of the economy – the good and the bad.

A bully blinks

Russian ship breaks U.S. blockade to help fuel-starved Cuba

Ever since U.S. President Donald Trump began his second term in office, his administration’s conduct of foreign policy has been that of a schoolyard bully. This is particularly true in 2026, when the U.S. launched attacks on two oil-rich countries, Venezuela and Iran. The first was on the blatantly false pretext of terming President Nicolás Maduro the head of a drug cartel and the second was at the instance of Israel. As with schoolyard bullies everywhere, the Trump administration recognises no rules and mistakes the absence of violent resistance for proof of its strength. The strangling of Cuba is a case in point. After seizing Venezuela’s energy assets, abducting its President and cutting off Venezuelan oil supply to Havana, the U.S. threatened countries such as Mexico that sought to step into the breach, and imposed a de facto naval blockade on Cuba, leading to a severe fuel crunch and acute distress for ordinary Cubans. This behaviour, justified by Mr. Trump as an attempt to take over Cuba and remove its decades-long communist government, is part of a strategy so nakedly imperial that it has been termed the “Don-roe Doctrine”, a crude play on the original instrument of U.S. hemispheric dominance for over two centuries. Yet, the bully’s power is often brittle and holds only until someone calls the bluff. When Russia, Cuba’s ally since the Soviet era, dispatched a tanker, the *Anatoly Kolodkin*, as humanitarian aid to fuel-starved Cuba, it also tested the will of the Trump administration to interdict a ship owned by another nuclear power. The tanker reached without incident.

The U.S., it turns out, did not push back and the bluff now stands exposed, even if by a country that has itself displayed similar behaviour in neighbouring Ukraine. Cuba’s fuel crisis has not ended and the threat of American attacks still hangs over the socialist government led by President Miguel Díaz-Canel. But Russia’s timely help reveals that the rest of the world need not simply endure the Trump era as this administration goes about breaking every accepted tenet of the international order. For all its flaws as a one-party state, Cuba has been an avowed member of the Non-Aligned Movement, has shown solidarity with the Global South by deploying well-trained doctors for medical programmes across poor countries, and has contributed materially to anti-colonial struggles for decades. It is time other countries repaid the Cubans by showing the will to break the American blockade and continue sovereign trade and commerce with Cuba, asserting their right to do so. After all, the international order holds only when its constituents accept that might does not always make right.

West Asia is currently enmeshed in what is essentially Benjamin Netanyahu’s war, aggravated by Donald Trump’s folly, lending itself to large-scale devastation. The conflict that began on February 28, 2026, when the United States and Israel launched large-scale joint military operations against Iran, is still continuing. What appeared to be a limited confrontation earlier in June (the 12-day war in June 2025) may now be seen as a kind of curtain raiser for this – the more devastating conflict taking place now. Titled ‘Operation Epic Fury’, the human cost of the war has been colossal, apart from other types of collateral damage. With several thousand Iranians killed, more than half of them civilians, it is apparent that the U.S. and Israel are preparing for a long campaign and, incidentally, in course of time, to commit troops on the ground. The world, nevertheless, needs to prepare for a long-drawn-out conflict

Iran survives the onslaught

To date, despite the widespread disruption and devastation, including the assassination of senior Iranian leaders such as Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and National Security Chief Ali Larijani among others, Iran has not only survived but its uranium stockpile also remains safe. Iran appears ready for an extended war. Also, Iran hopes to get its own back on the U.S., Israel, and their allies in the region by provoking a serious oil crisis through a blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, through which nearly 30% of the world’s shipment of oil passes. There has been other collateral damage as well, including the fact that many U.S. allies in Europe and elsewhere have openly refused to respond to Mr. Trump’s plaintive appeal for help in opening the Strait of Hormuz, even as Iran has made a tempting offer of safe passage (through the Strait) for countries friendly to it. Having survived the initial onslaught of the combined forces of the U.S. and Israel, Iran is now beginning to raise the stakes, at least as far as the U.S. is concerned, by calling for an American commitment to withdraw its bases in West Asia, to restrain Israel and arrive at an armistice of sorts.

Most experts believe that, if anything, time is on the side of Iran. Despite all the fire and fury visited on Iran in the first month of the conflict, and despite the loss of its top leaders, Iran has not only survived but has also managed to hit back, though with lesser intensity. The regime’s command structure has been disrupted, but a collapse of the Iranian state has not occurred. On the other hand, for the U.S., its strategy of saturation bombardment from the air is leading to certain other repercussions, in terms of both cost and replenishments of key weapons such as Patriot missiles, Terminal High Altitude Area



M.K. Narayanan

A former Director, Intelligence Bureau, a former National Security Adviser, and a former Governor of West Bengal

As the West Asia conflict – widely seen as Benjamin Netanyahu’s war – falters, Iran appears to be enduring while the world grapples with growing economic strain

Defense (THAAD) Interceptors, Tomahawk cruise missiles and the like. Within the U.S., more so among sections of the U.S. Navy, signs of war weariness appear to have set in; while it is possible to overstate its significance, it cannot be ignored. In this respect, Israel’s strategy of containing the threat posed by Iran, while firing from Mr. Trump’s shoulders, may have gone awry. It would seem that the conflict has upended the Thucydides aphorism that “the strong do what they can and the weak suffer what they must”, for in the present case, Iran has refused to accept suffering without hitting back with full ferocity. Notwithstanding this, the U.S. and Israel display few compunctions in persisting with a conflict that is focused ‘on extracting advantage, rather than in underwriting order’.

‘Netanyahu’s war’ escalates

This is undoubtedly Mr. Netanyahu’s war, and while standard declamations may continue to be made, it is apparent that Mr. Netanyahu’s plans to decimate Iran with the aid and the support of the U.S. has gone wrong. What is surprising also is that, apart from U.S. support to Israel’s devious plans, much of the rest of the civilised world has not upbraided Israel for embarking on a patently illegal conflict, which has no merit whatsoever. The world continues to remain a mute spectator, notwithstanding the price it is paying due to the escalating cost of oil.

Israel’s obsession about seeking fulfilment of the ‘Biblical Promise of the chosen land’, notwithstanding the huge cost in human and economic terms, is unfortunately proving costly for the world at large as well. However, Israel remains adamant in pursuing the war with little regard for the costs involved, and, with Mr. Trump’s backing, hopes to expand the ambit of the conflict across West Asia to include Lebanon, Iraq, and Syria. All this, despite the already apparent severe maritime disruptions and retaliatory steps taken by Iran such as the closing of the Strait of Hormuz.

The Iran war today has entered a phase of ‘no peace, no large-scale war’, one defined not merely by military confrontation but through the weaponisation of the infrastructure underpinning the global economy. Energy prices, shipping lanes and logistical systems provide the essential backdrop to the current conflict and are, in a sense, central to the strategy of those involved. The U.S. has far more to lose than Israel if the world plunges into prolonged chaos – but the economies of most nations across the globe are already being, and would continue to be, adversely affected by the disruption of the oil economy and its fallout in every sphere.

Notwithstanding the opinion of military experts that Israel’s objective of effecting a regime change in Iran is impossible without a ground

invasion, Israel is pursuing such an objective with vigour. Neither the U.S. nor Europe display any enthusiasm for this. The economies of most nations concerned are, once again, in no position to undertake such a conflict – including the U.S. Both China and Russia are almost certain to oppose it. A war of this kind is, moreover, certain to throw up many other issues often lost sight of in the Councils of the World. The fact that Iran is a large country is often ignored, as also that Iranian forces are better acclimatised to carry out a war of attrition. Reliance on air power provides no significant advantage to any ‘aggressor’.

On Shia resistance

Additionally, one must add a symbolic dimension to any conflict that is aimed at overthrowing a Shiite regime. Shiite political culture draws heavily on the memory of the ‘Battle of Karbala’ that symbolises civilisational resistance, and not just geopolitics. The narrative emphasises patience, sacrifice, resistance and strategic endurance. A war intended to change the present dispensation in Iran by outside forces such as Israel, would only provide an opportunity to enhance the religious, political and transnational aspects of Shiite Islam.

Expansion of the current war launched by the U.S. and Israel is more likely to be perceived as approximating to striking at the roots of political Shiism – in Iran and elsewhere. Western military superiority does not guarantee strategic victory. Nor will a war automatically result in altering geopolitical outcomes inside Iran and across the region, or to a regime collapse in Iran. All this would pave the way for a long drawn-out war, irrespective of the consequences.

The appointment of Mojtaba Khamenei as the Supreme Leader following Ali Khamenei’s killing on February 28, should again be viewed not as a mere rite of passage but as a triumph for the radical messianic-apocalyptic aspect of Shiite Islam. In a sense, it is triggering a revival of Shiite militancy – and in an aggravated form. This leaves little room for any expectation that the revolutionary fervour will diminish with the killing of additional Ayatollahs.

The U.S. and Israel, hence, need to be careful before venturing into the ‘spider’s web’, for the cost of delusion could be grave not only for Israel and the U.S. but also for the world at large. There is still time, at least for the U.S., to retrieve the situation and alter the policy direction that has been initiated under Mr. Netanyahu’s instigation. Israel’s deliberate provocation, including its latest attack very close to Iran’s Bushehr nuclear power plant (built with Russian collaboration) was a needless – and perhaps a deliberate – act of provocation by Israel. Such issues need to be avoided lest the world is plunged into third world war, with untold sufferings for mankind.

Counting people is not counting disaster risk

Odisha is, by any measure, one of India’s most disaster-prone States. Its 574.7-kilometre coastline has absorbed some of the most powerful cyclones to make landfall on the subcontinent. Over two decades, through investment in early warning systems, cyclone shelters, and mass evacuations, the State has reduced cyclone mortality to near zero. It is, therefore, not merely paradoxical but troubling that the 16th Finance Commission has awarded Odisha the single largest reduction in disaster funding share among all 28 States, a decline of 1.57 percentage points relative to the 15th Finance Commission’s allocation.

How does a State with the highest hazard score in the country, and the deepest investments in preparedness, end up losing the most? The answer lies in a structural problem in the Finance Commission’s allocation formula.

The revised formula and its rationale

The 16th Finance Commission has allocated ₹2,04,401 crore to State Disaster Response Funds (SDRF), a 59.5% increase over its predecessor. The Commission adopted a multiplicative Disaster Risk Index (DRI = Hazard X Exposure X Vulnerability), drawing on the theoretical framework. This is a departure from the additive approach of the 15th Finance Commission, which treated hazard and vulnerability as substitutes rather than complements. Risk arises only when hazard intersects with exposed and vulnerable populations. A powerful cyclone striking an uninhabited coastline is a natural event, not a disaster. The logic is correct. The operationalisation is not.

The first problem lies in the measurement of ‘Exposure’. The Commission uses the total population of each State, scaled linearly between 1 and 25, as its exposure metric. Uttar Pradesh receives 25 and Sikkim receives 1. This is administratively convenient but scientifically indefensible. Exposure, per the United Nations Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change



Aswathy Rachel Varughese

Assistant Professor, Gulati Institute of Finance and Taxation, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala

Structural problems in the 16th Finance Commission’s disaster funding formula leave India’s most hazard-prone States underserved

(IPCC)’s Sixth Assessment Report, is the presence of people in places that could be adversely affected by hazards, not simply the number of people within a political boundary. A State with 10 crore people on a hazard-safe inland plateau has lower exposure than a State with three crore people settled entirely along a cyclone-prone coastline. Total population and hazard-zone population are not the same variable.

The practical consequences are stark. Odisha’s hazard score of 12 is the highest in the country. But because its population score is only 5, its computed DRI of 79.8 is overshadowed by Bihar’s 224.2 and Uttar Pradesh’s 413.2, two States with lower hazard scores. The multiplicative formula, in practice, rewards demographic size. A State can face the most intense hazard in India and still lose funding because it is not populous. This is precisely the outcome that a risk-based allocation framework was designed to prevent.

The second problem compounds the first. Vulnerability is measured through each State’s average per capita Net State Domestic Product (NSDP), inverted so that poorer States score higher. The intuition is clear – poorer States have fewer fiscal resources to absorb disaster shocks. But the NSDP measures fiscal capacity, not disaster vulnerability. Vulnerability is multidimensional, encompassing housing quality, health infrastructure in hazard zones, early warning reach, and the share of population in structurally unsafe dwellings. Average per capita income conceals enormous intra-state inequality.

In 2018, Kerala suffered its worst flooding in a century, causing estimated damages of ₹31,000 crore. Yet, the formula assigns Kerala a vulnerability score of just 1.073, near the minimum, because its per capita income is relatively high. Combined with a population score of 4, Kerala’s DRI, of 34.5, is lower than many States with negligible disaster history. Jharkhand, with the second-highest vulnerability score reflecting genuine poverty and tribal fragility, still loses 0.78 percentage points of funding share

because its population score cannot compensate in the multiplicative framework. Twenty States in total have lost relative share. The common thread is not that they are safer; it is that they are smaller, wealthier on average, or both.

What needs to change

Exposure should be measured as the number of people living within defined hazard zones, flood plains, cyclone-prone coastal belts, earthquake-susceptible zones, using the Building Materials and Technology Promotion Council (BMTPC) Vulnerability Atlas cross-referenced with Census enumeration block data. Vulnerability should be reconstituted as a composite index incorporating the share of kutcha housing, agricultural labour dependence, health infrastructure density in high-hazard districts, crop insurance penetration, and early warning effectiveness. The National Family Health Survey (NFHS)-5, the Pradhan Mantri Fasal Bima Yojana (PMFBY) database, National Health Mission (NHM) facility surveys, and India Meteorological Department (IMD) monitoring records collectively provide that information. The Finance Commission should mandate the National Disaster Management Authority to publish an annual State Disaster Vulnerability Index as the authoritative input for each subsequent award period, institutionalising the methodology and ending contested metrics at every Commission.

India cannot afford to get disaster finance wrong. Climate projections indicate intensifying cyclone frequencies along both coastlines, expanding drought belts across peninsular and central India, and escalating extreme rainfall in already-stretched States. The States most likely to face the sharpest increase in disaster frequency – Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, Kerala, Assam – are precisely those the current formula underserves. A formula that measures total population rather than the exposed population is not a risk index. It is a headcount.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Rupee’s steep fall

It is amusing that Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman has gone on record to state that the Indian rupee is doing “absolutely fine” thanks to robust economic fundamentals. Comparisons with peers such as the Thai Baht and Philippine Peso conveniently hides the fact that the rupee plunged

10.96% in FY 26, its deepest fall in 14 years, making it Asia’s worst performing currency. One cannot forget that the rupee was the only Asian currency to withstand the onslaught of the Asian currency crisis, in 1997, and remain stable against the dollar, when all other Asian currencies were in trouble. This was possible only due to the intelligent manner in

which our currency was managed by the financial wizards who were at the helm of affairs.

Tharcus S. Fernando,
Chennai

The safety pin

This is no exaggeration, but the bonding that a safety pin has with clothing is much like a mother’s bond with her child (Open Page –

“Ode to the safety pin”, March 29). Its brilliance lies in its versatility – mending, crafting, and emergency repairs. As a common practice, sterilised safety pins are used for removing thorns or splinters from the bottom of feet. In times of social and political unrest, it has been adopted as a symbol of unity, solidarity, and resistance. Its simple

form and accessibility have made the safety pin a powerful tool for expressing collective sentiment.

R. Sivakumar,
Chennai

In Guwahati

Chennai Super Kings totally looked out of sorts in their first match of this edition of the Indian Premier League in Guwahati on Monday.

That the team was all out for just 127 runs in 19.4 overs against Rajasthan Royals was deplorable indeed. Powered by lad Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Rajasthan Royals made it a one-sided contest.

S. Ramakrishnasayee,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

An impeachment move with no winners

A win-win situation benefits all stakeholders even if a compromise is reached in search of a workable alternative. It could even be a way in which the winning side deludes the losing side to perceive its loss as a necessary price it paid for survival.

The impeachment motion of the Opposition parties against the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) is one such example. It is a motion destined not to carry. Yet its prime movers may not see the loss as a defeat. But can the CEC see their loss as his victory?

The move of the Opposition parties is doubtlessly dramatic. However, the question that needs to be pondered by the well-wishers of the Election Commission of India (ECI) is what prompted them to don the gloves for a fight with no chance of victory. Perhaps, sometimes one fights not to win but to wound the opponent. And the troubling part is that political parties treat the CEC as an opponent.

Steadfast defiance

The move to impeach the CEC is a first in the history of an institution that is supposed to be a vanguard of Indian electoral democracy. “India built many institutions after attaining freedom and adopting a Republican constitution...If anyone were to conduct an opinion poll on which of these institutions rendered the best service to Indian democracy with the highest degree of integrity, I have no doubt that the ECI will be our people’s first choice,” said Atal Bihari Vajpayee, the then Prime Minister at the ECI’s golden jubilee celebrations on January 17, 2001.

And now, 25 years later, 193 parliamentarians of the Opposition have submitted notices for an impeachment motion against the CEC citing charges of “partisan and discriminatory conduct”, “obstruction of investigation into electoral fraud” and disenfranchisement via the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. The notice is as



Ashok Lavasa

Former Election Commissioner and Union Finance Secretary of India

unprecedented as the manner in which the revision of electoral rolls has been undertaken despite serious challenge by most political parties, except the ruling dispensation. Such an alignment of thinking disconcerted the Opposition, which sharpened their attack against the CEC. The repeated press conferences by the Leader of the Opposition (LOP) exposing discrepancies in the electoral rolls of States where elections had been held, further eroded trust in the body.

While the aggressive style and severity of the LOP’s attack on the poll body, questioning its integrity was surprising, what was more surprising was the poll body’s obduracy in not providing a credible response to the doubts raised on its functioning and impartiality. As the attacks became more and more bitter, communication channels between the poll body and the opposition political parties seemed to choke.

The nation had seldom seen such a relentless campaign against a CEC even as the Supreme Court heard endless petitions against his decisions. As the petitions failed to yield any substantive relief, frustration mounted and so did the CEC’s apparent indifference. The CEC persisted with the SIR despite the fortnight-long Vote Adhikar Yatra just before the Bihar State elections.

Not that there was no dialogue. The one between the poll body and the Trinamool Congress caused more rancour culminating in the theatrical presence of Mamata Banerjee in the Supreme Court. Never before had a Chief Minister appeared in Court arguing against the ECI’s unfair decisions. The dharnas against the SIR in West Bengal or officials dying in the course of conducting the SIR failed to deter the CEC or change his avowed commitment to “purify” the electoral rolls.

The ECI invented the “logical discrepancy” tool that pitted electors against the AI used to detect discrepancies. West Bengal saw 58,20,899 electors deleted at

the draft stage and 60,06,675 “under adjudication” in the final list. But the ECI went on to announce elections in the State, where the fate of nearly 10% electors remained undetermined. It employed micro-observers for finalising the revised rolls, something never done in the past. The SC also took the extraordinary step of appointing over 500 judicial officers to decide the fate of these electors in a short span.

It is unusual for a constitutional body mandated with electoral rolls preparation to involve another constitutional body in discharging its routine functions by disregarding the elector’s voting right, which it was created to protect. The exclusion of even a single eligible voter due to the way the SIR has been conducted would legitimise the criticism of this arbitrary and aggressive exercise.

A loss for the common man

However, does all of this justify the impeachment move? The answer depends on which side of the divide one stands. The crores of voters who figure in the final electoral roll might not protest, treating the tension and trauma during the revision process as part of the routine struggle that helpless citizens go through to secure their rights. The voice of those excluded doesn’t count in the elections in any case.

Eventually, the valid concern of protecting the right to vote turns into the lament of losers who are left with no choice but to resort to the ultimate constitutional weapon against the CEC.

Meanwhile, the ECI has sounded the poll bugle asking players to contest against each other rather than against the referee. It is now in full control. The successful completion of the poll process will justify all its decisions. Victors will exult; losers will find reasons to complain.

What the nation would be left with will be a poll body in which the Opposition, representing more than half the voting population, has expressed no confidence.

The TVK makes a go for it alone

The party seems to have not learnt its lesson from the Karur stampede

STATE OF PLAY

T. Ramakrishnan
ramakrishnan.t@thehindu.co.in



The fledgling Tamilaga Vetti Kazhagam (TVK), on March 29, crossed one of the most important stages of the electoral process, by naming candidates for all the 234 Assembly constituencies in the State.

Ever since the initial excitement about the TVK’s entry into the political scene started evaporating after the Karur stampede that killed 41 persons in September last year, the party’s founder C. Joseph Vijay (Tamil actor known only as Vijay) became a target of attack from his critics. Thanks to his party’s litigation, the stampede case was transferred to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) from a Madras High Court-appointed Special Investigation Team (SIT) and a State-constituted enquiry commission. In two spells spread over two months, Mr. Vijay has faced interrogation by the CBI in New Delhi. Meanwhile, the talk of a decisive shift in the TVK’s stand on the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), which Mr. Vijay had called all along as the “ideological adversary,” began doing the rounds a day before the actor-turned politician left for New Delhi. Sections of the media frantically reported that a host of district secretaries of the TVK had expressed, at an internal meeting held virtually, their preference for an alliance with the BJP.

Mr. Vijay had made it clear at the TVK’s inaugural State-level conference in October 2024, that he was open to having pre-poll alliances and a coalition government, a concept which is anathema to the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam

(DMK) and the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK). Yet, barring the AIADMK and the BJP which had sought to court the TVK, others, including allies of the DMK, stayed aloof in the light of buzz from certain quarters that the Congress and the Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi might move towards the TVK.

An interesting potpourri

It was against this backdrop that the TVK came out with its list of nominees in one go. As of now, only one more party – the 16-year-old Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK) – is contesting in all the seats. Mr. Vijay is contesting from Perambur in north Chennai, once a seat reserved for Scheduled Castes (SCs) but now a general constituency with economically vulnerable sections of society living in large numbers, and from Tiruchi East, a seat in the central region of the State with a substantial population of Christians, especially Vellalas (the denomination to which Mr. Vijay’s father S.A. Chandrasekhar belongs), and Muslims. The party has fielded many of its prominent faces in Chennai, including AIADMK’s former veteran, J.C.D. Prabhakar (Thousand Lights), and the TVK’s general secretary ‘Bussy’ N. Anand (T. Nagar).

As per an estimate, about 45% of the candidates –106 nominees – are from other parties. While no one would have anything negative to

comment about giving tickets to former School Education Minister K.A. Sengottaiyan and his associate V. Sathyabama, who, as Tiruppur’s MP during 2014-19, took her job seriously in terms of participating in debates (both joined the party about four months ago), Mr. Vijay’s decision with respect to some others caused disquiet among party cadres. There was an element of surprise over the inclusion of two former MLAs of the Dravidian major, Dusi K. Mohan and Reddiyarpatti V. Narayanan and a senior office-bearer of the Congress D. Selvam, all of whom joined the TVK at the last minute. When the TVK founder held a meeting at a hotel in Chennai, sections of party cadres staged a demonstration outside the hotel, protesting against the choice of candidate for K.V. Kuppam, a constituency reserved for SCs in Vellore.

Lack of crowd control

On the first day of filing nominations, Mr. Vijay submitted his papers in Perambur but his plan for campaigning in three Chennai seats suffered a setback as he was not able to cover the third constituency, for which his party blamed the police. While after the Karur stampede, TVK functionaries would be expected to be more meticulous to detail, this campaign incident proves that they have become none the wiser. Instead of blaming the police or officials, the party managers should take a cue from how crowd management was handled during the annual temple festival of Arubathumooavar (idols of the 63 Nayanmars) on the same day in Mylapore smoothly, despite the event being watched by thousands of devotees. Else, one does not have to hazard a great guess about the result.

How women voters are shaping State politics in 2026

Even though women are increasingly shaping party strategies and political outcomes, their representation in State Assemblies remain low

DATA POINT

Sanjay Kumar
Vibha Attri

Women voters have become a central point of discussion in elections in India in recent times. Rightly so, because parties in power roll out women-centric schemes, sometimes even direct cash transfer ones, to win their support. Opposition parties too make promises about initiating schemes for women’s welfare, if elected. These promises seem to making some impact, reflected in the rising turnout of women voters. Parties appear to have mobilised women through welfare schemes, and this mobilisation is seen as a key factor for electoral success.

The upcoming Assembly elections in Assam, Kerala, West Bengal and Tamil Nadu are unlikely to be different. Women, who constitute nearly half of the electorate in each State (and slightly more in Kerala), are a key focus of all political parties. Electoral trends show that while turnout has increased, women remain underrepresented in State assemblies. However, evidence from Lokniti-CSDS data suggest that their voting choices have somewhat shaped party strategies and political outcomes.

Across all four States, women’s voter turnout has remained high and largely stable over the past three decades, often matching or slightly exceeding men’s participation (**Table 1**). In Assam, the gender gap narrowed from -1.48 percentage points in 1991 to +0.41 in 2021. Kerala shows a similar trend, with women voting at levels equal to or slightly higher than men. In 2016, women’s turnout surpassed men’s, with a gap of +2.17 percentage points. By 2021, the turnout was nearly equal, with a gap of +0.09 percentage points.

In West Bengal, women’s turnout remained slightly below men’s until 2011, when it sur-

passed men’s for the first time and maintained a marginal lead in the subsequent election (+0.38 percentage points in 2021). Tamil Nadu, historically lower in voter participation compared to other States, reached near parity by 2011, and women’s turnout has remained close to men’s turnout through 2021, with only a minimal gap of -0.27 percentage points.

Representation in Assemblies

While women have consistently shown high voter participation, converting this engagement into representation in State Assemblies remains a persistent challenge. Over the past three decades, the proportion of women elected to Assemblies in all four States have varied, but remained low.

In Assam, women’s representation rose from 3.97% in 1991 to a peak of 11.11% in 2011, but fell to 4.76% in 2021 (six of 126 seats). Kerala shows a relatively stable but persistently low level of women’s representation, with women legislators occupying between 5% and 9% of seats over the years. In 2021, only 11 women were elected, accounting for just 7.86% of the 140-seat Assembly.

West Bengal stands out for gradual gains rising from 7.14% in 1991 to 13.95% in 2016, and 13.61% in 2021. In 2021 about 40 women were elected to the 294-member Assembly, the highest among these States. Tamil Nadu presents the most volatile trajectory. Representation peaked at 13.68% in 1991 but fell sharply to 3.85% in 1996. In 2021, women’s representation stood at 5.13%, with 12 women elected to the 234-seat Assembly

On voting patterns

Survey-based estimates from Assembly election studies conducted by the Lokniti-CSDS provide insight into how women have voted over time. In Assam, there has been a clear shift. In 2011, the Congress led among women voters with 39% of women voting for them, while the BJP secured 10%.

By 2021, the BJP-led alliance increased its women’s vote share to 44%. The Mahajot alliance also secured significant support, receiving 33% in 2016 and 41% in 2021, making the contest more competitive (**Table 2**).

Kerala presents a closely contested pattern between the United Democratic Front (UDF) and the Left Democratic Front (LDF) with women’s support nearly equal in 2011 and 2016. In the 2021 Assembly elections, the LDF gained a modest advantage securing 45% of women’s votes compared to the UDF’s 41%. The BJP which contested independently in 2011 received 5% of the women’s votes. In 2016 and 2021, contesting as part of an alliance, its share rose to 12% and 11% respectively, but it remains a secondary player in a largely bipolar contest (**Table 3**).

In West Bengal, the Trinamool Congress (AITC), whether contesting alone or in alliance, has consistently secured close to 50% of the women’s vote. The BJP, contesting independently in 2011 and 2016, received 4% and 10% of the women’s votes, respectively. By 2021, the BJP and its allies expanded sharply among women voters, receiving 36% of the votes, pointing to some restructuring of the electoral landscape (**Table 4**).

Tamil Nadu shows alternating patterns between the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) and the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK). The AIADMK led among women voters in 2016 (46%), but the DMK alliance overtook it in 2021 with 45% compared to the 42% of the AIADMK and its allies (**Table 5**).

Despite their high participation, women remain a small minority in State legislatures. Over the past three decades, structural barriers such as limited party nominations, competitive electoral dynamics and social and cultural constraints have constrained representation. Yet, their voting patterns increasingly shape party strategies and influence political contests.

Women's electoral power

The data for the tables were sourced from Lokniti-CSDS



TABLE 1: The gender gap in voter turnout in State elections. (+) indicates higher turnout of women compared to men, (-) indicates lower turnout of women

Year	Assam	Kerala	West Bengal	Tamil Nadu
2021	+0.41	+0.09	+0.38	-0.27
2016	+0.34	+2.17	+0.9	+0.17
2011	-1.91	-0.3	+0.23	+0.98
2006	-1.6	-2.09	-1.59	-3.66
2001	-5.49	-3.72	-5.3	-4.47
1996	-2.54	-1.65	-1.94	-4.3
1991	-1.48	-0.31	-1.57	-4.25

TABLE 2: Party-wise women's voting trends in Assam Assembly elections (in %)

Year	Mahajot/Congress/Congress+	NDA/BJP	AIUDF	Others
2021	41	44	-	15
2016	33	42	13	12
2011	39	10	13	38

TABLE 3: Party-wise women's voting trends in Kerala Assembly elections (in %)

Year	UDF	LDF	NDA/BJP	Others
2021	41	45	11	3
2016	42	42	12	4
2011	46	45	5	4

TABLE 4: Party-wise women's voting trends in West Bengal Assembly polls (in %)

Year	AITC/AITC	BJP+/BJP	Sanyukth Morcha/INC	Left	Others
2021	50	36	10	-	4
2016	47	10	11	25	7
2011	49	4	-	40	7

TABLE 5: Party-wise women's voting trends in Tamil Nadu Assembly polls (in %)

Year	DMK+	AIADMK/ADMK+	BJP	Others
2021	45	42	-	13
2016	35	46	3	16
2011	40	51	2	7

Sanjay Kumar is a Professor and Political Analyst.Vibha Attri is a Research Associate at Lokniti-CSDS

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO APRIL 1, 1976

Prosperity brigade and youth service corps to go

Madras, March 31: Both the Prosperity Brigade and the Youth Services corps started by the previous DMK regime in Tamil Nadu are to go.

While the Prosperity Brigade will be wound up immediately, the members of the YSC will be discharged on completion of four years of service. The Government found that the Brigade had ceased to be the non-political organisation that it purported to be, the contribution of YSC to improvement of rural economy was “not very satisfactory”.

At his weekly press conference to-day, the Governor Mr. K.K. Shah said the Brigade was brought into existence in February 1968 with the objective of developing local leadership and better utilisation of rural manpower. Over the past eight years, it had undertaken small works, which did not involve a high degree of technical skill, with the Government’s contribution ranging from 50 per cent for building works and 33-1/3 per cent for other works.

“The organisation was expected to be non-political in character. But, in fact, it was not so. Even the enlistment of volunteers at village level had a political bias,” he said. The organisational set-up and co-ordination at various levels were “not good”.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO APRIL 1, 1926

Royal geographical society

Rugby, March 31: Several prominent British explorers have been awarded medals with the approval of the King by Royal Geographical society.

These include Col. Norton, who has received the Founder’s Medal for his leadership of the Mount Everest expedition in 1924 and his ascent to 28,100 feet and Professor Sir Edgeworth David for his work on Fanafuti Atoll and his leadership of the first ascent of Mount Erebus and of the party which first visited the South Magnetic Pole.

Other awards and grants are given to Dr. John Ball for his desert surveys in Egypt, to Mr. Frank Debenham for scientific exploration of Antarctic to Afraz, Mr. Gul for his surveys in Central Asia and Mr. Hunza, to Major Kenneth Masen to assist his future exploration of Himalayas, to Dr. Gordon Thompson for his journey on Tibetan and Mongolian borders of China.

From Page One

Trump blasts allies, tells them ‘get your own oil’

“This is not our war and we’re not going to get drawn in to it,” Mr. Starmer had said on Monday, in reference to Iran, reiterating that the U.K.’s involvement was restricted to defensive action.

U.K. Defence Secretary John Healey, on a visit to West Asia, said on Tuesday that extra British troops and air defence systems would be deployed to the region, according to a BBC report.

Several European countries have disagreed publicly with the U.S.’s actions to varying degrees, with none joining the U.S. and Israel in striking Iran.

Remarks on France

Mr. Trump also took aim at France in his Tuesday posts.

“The Country of France wouldn’t let planes headed to Israel, loaded up with military supplies, fly over French territory. France has been VERY UNHELPFUL with respect to the ‘Butcher of Iran’ [Ayatollah Ali Khamenei] who has been successfully eliminated! The U.S.A. will REMEMBER!!!!” Mr. Trump wrote on Truth Social. *The Hindu* has reached out to the French foreign ministry for a response.

On Monday, Mr. Trump had threatened to destroy oil wells, power plants, Iran’s Kharg Island (an oil hub) and desalination plants, if Iran did not reach a deal with the U.S. and open up the Strait of Hormuz.

U.S. Secretary of War Pete Hegseth reiterated Mr. Trump’s message during a press briefing at the Pentagon on Tuesday. He said the world should “be prepared to stand up” and that it was not just America’s “problem set” going forward, claiming that the U.S. had done the “lion’s share” of opening up the Strait.

Eight killed in Bihar temple stampede

The incident took place as a large number of devotees, mostly women, had gathered to offer prayer at the temple in Maghra village, near Biharsharif town, on Tuesday morning, including many from the neighbouring districts of Patna and Nawada.

“Due to the heavy rush of devotees at the temple to offer prayer, a stampede happened in which eight lives were lost, some due to suffocation and some due to loss of water, Nalanda Superintendent of Police Bharat Soni said. Police personnel from neighbouring districts were called in to control the situation.

The Deep Nagar Station House Officer Rajmani was suspended, along with some others, and a Special Investigation Team (SIT) has been formed to probe the incident, said Bihar Director General of Police Vinay Kumar, who reached the site of the stampede along with other senior police officials from Patna. Bihar Chief Secretary Pratyaya Amrit has also been instructed to initiate a probe into the incident and submit a report to the government.

“All the injured persons have been admitted to the Sadar hospital at Biharsharif, the district headquarters, and are said to be out of danger,” said District Magistrate Kundan Kumar.

Mr. Kumar expressed his grief at the tragedy and announced an *ex gratia* of ₹6 lakh to the families of the victims, including ₹4 lakh from the Disaster Management Department and ₹2 lakh from the CM’s Relief Fund. Mr. Modi announced ₹2 lakh in financial aid to be paid to the families from the PM’s National Relief Fund, and ₹50,000 to the injured. Ms. Murmu also expressed her condolences to the bereaved families and prayed for the speedy recovery of the injured.

Rashtriya Janata Dal leader Tejashwi Yadav expressed his condolences and demanded that the State government “initiate a high-level probe into the stampede” and take care of all those injured in the incident.

‘India can comfortably cater to PNG demand’

India’s current production of natural gas was 90 million metric standard cubic meters per day. Therefore, India could comfortably cater to about 30 crore connections solely with its domestic production of natural gas itself, he said.

“Even if we are just reserving the [domestic natural gas] production for domestic PNG, we should be able to make provisions for 30 crore connections,” Mr. Mishra said. “So, even if you scale up to say two crore, or five crore, we are totally sufficient with respect to our domestic consumption.”

“We are trying to achieve 20,000 connections every day,” he said. “At present, we are hovering around 8,000-9,000 connections per day; we are definitely trying to scale the level.”

He further noted that, with permissions being accorded on a “war footing” by the government, municipal corporations, among other entities concerned, had played an active role in the attempt to reach the target.

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, in a gazette notification dated March 24, had introduced norms to help accelerate the uptake of and transition to PNG.

Addressing concerns about the requirement of additional capital expenditure amid the expedited push for PNG and pipeline expansion, Mr. Mishra said the accelerated push would provide the city gas distributors (CGDs) an opportunity to infuse their available capital more rapidly.

Violence erupts at Kolkata CEO office over Form 6 row

Mamata alleges that BJP is trying to smuggle outsiders into State voter list for ‘voter hijacking’; CEO says it is not his job to check Form 6 submissions; CM threatened Central forces, says BJP

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Violence erupted outside the Chief Electoral Officer’s office in Kolkata on Tuesday, with clashes between Trinamool Congress and BJP workers over allegations that Form 6, used for fresh inclusion of names on the electoral roll, is being submitted in large numbers in West Bengal.

Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee wrote to Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar about the issue. “BJP agents have been caught red-handed flooding the Office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), West Bengal with thousands of fraudulent Form 6 applications to smuggle non-residents into Bengal’s electoral rolls. This is an attempt at voter hijacking,” Ms. Banerjee alleged, calling for the Election Commission to punish such actions which are “illegal, unconstitutional, and fundamentally undemocratic in nature.”

In response, CEO Manoj Kumar Agarwal said: “This is not my work. I cannot keep checking who is bringing what into my office. Should I conduct elections in the whole State or keep doing this?”

An organisation of booth-level officers (BLOs) supported by the ruling Trinamool Congress alleged that it had caught a BJP worker carrying over 400 Form 6 applications into the CEO’s office. The BLOs and Trinamool workers staged a protest outside



The police intervene as BJP supporters gather outside EC office during Trinamool Congress protest in Kolkata on Tuesday. ANI

the office, flagging this issue. BJP workers also reached the spot and engaged with the Trinamool workers, leading to a heated exchange.

Protesters of the ruling party alleged that the BJP was trying to enroll voters from outside Bengal to influence the polls in its favour. Central forces and local police were both deployed to the spot to bring the tense situation under control. The police, armed with batons, charged protesters in a bid

to de-escalate the heated scuffle between the party workers.

This came a day after Trinamool Congress general secretary Abhishek Banerjee sent a formal complaint to the CEO, alleging that the EC is changing the demography of Bengal by including voters from Bihar and Uttar Pradesh in the State’s electoral rolls. He said the BJP had submitted at least 30,000 Form 6 applications in bulk.

Leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikari lodged a complaint against Ms. Banerjee for provoking voters against the Central forces. “She is asking the women of the house to fight the Central forces. This is a direct attack against the officers engaged in election work,” he alleged.

Meanwhile, the EC has started accepting online applications by voters who have been deleted from the final voter list but want to contest the decision in an appellate tribunal.

HC quashes petition against EC transfer of West Bengal officials

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Observing that the legality, validity and propriety of transfer orders issued by the Election Commission have not caused any public injury, the Calcutta High Court on Tuesday dismissed a PIL petition challenging the transfer of administrative and police officers in West Bengal.

“The transfer is an incident of service. If a transfer order runs contrary to any statutory provision, the aggrieved employee/officer can assail it in appropriate proceedings. In our view, the legality, validity and propriety of transfer orders which have not caused any public injury cannot be gone into a public interest litigation,” the order by the Division Bench of Chief Justice Sujoy Paul and Justice Partha Sarathi Sen said.

The EC has transferred a large number of officers since the Model Code of Conduct came into force. The Trinamool Congress has claimed that 395 officers have been transferred. The Bench noted that at-



The court said that attempts were made to link certain politicians and CEC.

tempts were made to link certain senior politicians and CEC Gyanesh Kumar. “The petitioner made an effort to establish a political nexus between certain senior politicians and the respondent. However, as rightly pointed out by learned counsel for the ECI, no such persons against whom allegations of connivance, pressure tactics etc. were alleged were impleaded by name. Thus, no allegation of malice can be entertained against the ECI. Apart from bald pleadings, no material could be placed to establish any such nexus,” the court noted.

‘Regional imbalance’ bothers Cong. as govt. plans delimitation to roll out women’s quota

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

The Union government’s proposal to carry out the delimitation exercise on the basis of the 2011 Census in order to implement the women’s reservation law by the 2029 Lok Sabha election has not only reversed its earlier position but has also prompted the Congress to nuance its stance.

Until recently, the government had maintained that the law could be implemented only after the completion of the delimitation exercise linked to the first Census conducted after 2026.

The Congress, which had earlier pressed for the immediate implementation of the women’s reservation law, is now demand-



As highlighted by Telangana Chief Minister... Uttar Pradesh: 80 → 120 seats, Telangana: 17 → 26 seats. The gap widens from 63 to 94 seats. Now look at the larger picture: southern States gain 66 seats (129 → 195), while northern States gain 200 seats

MANICKAM TAGORE
Congress MP



ing an all-party meeting to discuss the potential impact of such a move. Party leaders argue that if the strength of the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies is increased uniformly by around 50%, States with larger populations would automatically gain more seats, widening the existing representation gap.

The issue was first publicly flagged by Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy, who pointed to the implications of a population-based increase in seats for southern States. Except for Andhra Pradesh, where the Telugu Desam Party, a member of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA), is in power, the other southern States are ruled by non-NDA parties that could potentially take a common stance on the issue.

The Centre, however,

has already rejected the Congress’s demand for an all-party consultation.

“As highlighted by Telangana Chief Minister @revanth_anumula garu – Uttar Pradesh: 80 → 120 seats, Telangana: 17 → 26 seats. The gap widens from 63 to 94 seats. Now look at the larger picture: Southern States gain 66 seats (129 → 195), while northern States gain 200 seats,” Congress MP Manickam Tagore said in a post on X.

Though no official proposal has been placed in the public domain, government sources are said to be examining the possibility of increasing the strength of the Lok Sabha from 543 to around 816 seats, with 33% reserved for women in line with the provisions of the women’s reservation law.

42,000-sq. km Bastar largely free from violence, but IEDs remain a challenge

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

From tracking the movement of security teams out on patrol with satellite-enabled navigation devices and ensuring communication through satellite phones, to opening new security camps in the so-called liberated zones in the Bastar division of Chhattisgarh, the State Police and the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) followed a clear strategy to declare the 42,000-sq. km area “Maoist-free” by March 31, a deadline set by Union Home Minister Amit Shah on August 24, 2024.

The number of districts affected by left-wing extremism, often referred to as the red corridor, has shrunk from 126 districts across Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Odisha, West Bengal, Bihar, Maharashtra, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, and Madhya Pradesh in 2014 to just two districts – Bijapur and Sukma (in Chhattisgarh) – in 2026. In 2005 the number of affected districts stood at around



Former Maoist insurgents attend a vocational training programme in Dantewada district. AFP

230. Many districts were reorganised in the following years.

Bihar, Maharashtra (barring one district), Jharkhand, and Odisha had already been declared free of Maoist activities before 2024, Home Minister Amit Shah informed the Lok Sabha on March 30. Bastar was one of the regions worst affected by left-wing extremism.

Sundarraaj P., Inspector-General of Police, Bastar Range, told *The Hindu* that as new security camps were opened in Bastar, the

Police Action and Outcome Report, security camps are no longer limited to troop deployment but operate as Integrated Development Centres, helping extend governance, welfare schemes, and essential services to previously inaccessible villages. The expansion of these camps is described as central to restoring territorial control and public trust.

Mr. Sundarraaj said that though the area had been almost cleared of the presence of Maoists, with the exception of seven or eight cadres, the challenge posed by Improvised Explosive Devices (IED) remained. “We will take some time to de-mine the areas and declare them free of IEDs that may have been planted by the Maoists before they deserted their camps or surrendered,” Mr. Sundarraaj said.

Mr. Sundarraaj said that the incidents of Maoists damaging infrastructure had decreased significantly, with only two incidents of damage to mobile phone towers reported in 2025.

NIA, ED bust Maoist extortion, money laundering rackets

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A sustained and coordinated crackdown by various agencies, including the National Investigation Agency (NIA) and the Enforcement Directorate (ED), has disrupted the financial networks of banned Maoist outfits in recent years.

The NIA has a dedicated anti-Naxal vertical that is probing over 100 cases and has filed chargesheets in almost 90 cases. It has also seized assets worth more than ₹40 crore.

Among the major cases is the 2019 Tiriya encounter (Chhattisgarh), in which it has charged five senior Maoist operatives, besides others. In the Magadh (Bihar) revival case, 10 weapons and ₹4.03 crore in cash were seized.

Under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, the ED has attached assets worth more than ₹12 crore and filed prosecution complaints against the Maoists who targeted businessmen, contractors, workers, and even truck drivers for “protection money”.



APPEAL

Shri Koushik is 11 years old suffering from Heart Ailment and is advised VSD Closure & PDA Closure at Public Health Centre, Chennai. The total expenditure is Rs. 2,00,000/-. His father is working in a tea shop with poor income. They are not in a position to meet the cost of the treatment. Please help him to undergo the surgery and lead a healthy life. The donations sent through Ch/D./ M.O/ NEFT Transfer & GOOGLE PAY (Canara Bank, Nungambakkam Branch, A/c No. 60182010063310, IFSC No: CNRB0016018) favouring **WOMEN’S WELFARE SYNDICATE** is exempted under 80G IT. Your e-mail ID is requested.

All correspondence is done through **WWS**, Regd Public Charitable Trust, Flat No. GF 1, Cordell Apartments, O.No.13, N.No. 29, Pycrofts Garden Lane, Chennai-600006. Ph: 044-42137401/ 31523781/ 7339878027. E-mail ID: womenswelfare Syndicate@gmail.com.

WWS

ASSEMBLY POLLS

Leander Paes joins BJP ahead of Bengal polls

▼ Ahead of the election in West Bengal, Indian tennis legend Leander Paes on Tuesday joined the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) at the party headquarters.

Union Ministers Kiren Rijiju and Sukanta Majumdar, along with Anil Baluni, MP, were present on the occasion. In October 2021, prior to

the Goa Assembly election, Mr. Paes had joined the Trinamool Congress in the presence of party chief and West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee. Mr. Paes, born in Kolkata in 1973, is a descendant of 19th-century Bengali poet and dramatist Michael Madhusudan Dutt. One of India's most successful tennis players, Mr. Paes has won 18 Grand Slam titles and bagged a bronze medal in singles at the 1996 Atlanta Olympics.



Tennis legend Leander Paes joined the BJP on Tuesday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

BJP names 13 more candidates for Bengal polls

▼ The BJP on Tuesday announced the names of 13 candidates for the West Bengal polls, including Union Minister Shantanu Thakur's wife Soma Thakur for the Bagda seat. Shyamal Hati will contest Howrah Dakshin, Girija Shankar Roy Natabari, Ashutosh Barma Sital, and

Uttam Kumar Banik Magrahat Purb. Debangshu Panda will enter the fray from Falta, Debashish Dhar from Sonarpur Uttar and Ranjan Kumar Paul from Panchla. Santhosh Pathak will be contesting from Chowrangee, Piyush Kanti Das from Chandipur, Pradeep Lodha from Garbeta, Manav Guha from Memari, Arijit Roy from Barabani and Dalim Roy from Maynaguri. Polling for the 294-member West Bengal Assembly will be held on April 23 and 29. PTI



It is not about making someone an MLA or Himanta Assam CM again. It is about chasing out every infiltrator from our country SMRITI IRANI BJP leader

IPS officers given additional duties in Bengal

▼ The Kolkata Police has nominated senior IPS officers Nilanjan Biswas, Ajoy Prasad and Subhankar Bhattacharya to take up additional duties as nodal officers for the District Election Officers of Kolkata North, Kolkata South and South 24 Parganas district, respectively, according to an official order. PTI



Both the MP and the MLA in Balurghat [in Bengal] are from the BJP. Yet they have not brought even 10 paise of additional funds for this area ABHISHEK BANERJEE Trinamool Congress secretary



Poll race: Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin campaigns in Tiruvannamalai on Tuesday. ANI

Poll campaign turns into a sop opera in Tamil Nadu

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

With the Assembly election to be held in three weeks, it is time for major parties in Tamil Nadu, which has earned the sobriquet of “freebie State”, to come up with their own schemes of enticements for electors, totalling over 5.67 crore. Among the proposals on the table are an increase in the amount of monthly assistance for women from ₹1,000 to ₹2,000, and coupons worth ₹8,000 for every non-income tax-paying woman (homemaker) to buy consumer durables, both promised by the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), whose electoral promise of providing ₹1,000 each to women was regarded as one of the factors responsible for the return of the Dravidian major to power after a 10-year gap. There are other schemes, such as Pudhumai Penn and Tamil Puthalvan, both aimed at encouraging government school students to pursue higher education, wherein the party has assured the electorate that the assistance amount would go up to ₹1,500.

Assistance for one crore women The ruling party's traditional adversary, the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), which began issuing its dose of poll guarantees in mid-January and concluded it in the last week of March by issuing a comprehensive poll manifesto, was the first to announce the enhanced assistance of ₹2,000 each to women. In an act of one-upmanship, the party stated that all women holding family cards would be covered. This means the number of beneficiaries would be increased by one crore from the current 1.23 crore. If this assurance is implemented, the annual outlay would shoot up to around ₹55,200 crore. The party has promised free refrigerators for all rice cardholders, numbering about 2.22 crore. There are a host of other benefits, including free 1 kg lentils and 1 kg of cooking oil, for beneficiaries of the public distribution system. Not to be left behind, the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) has proposed hiking the assistance amount to ₹2,500 for women, giving one sovereign of gold under the marriage assistance scheme and providing an unemployment allowance of ₹4,000 for graduates, which is similar to that of the AIADMK that offers ₹2,000. There is an “odd man out” in the form of the Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK), which is against freebies as a matter of principle.

Rising revenue deficit The promises come at a time when the State's revenue deficit for 2026-27 is estimated to be ₹48,700 crore, a figure worked out independently of such offers. Besides, Tamil Nadu has been, at the all-India level, assessed as one of those States whose expenditure on subsidies as a percentage of revenue receipts exceeds the national average. It is an open secret that the promises of freebies alone do not guarantee victory to any party, as invariably every other party has been making such promises. Though some public policy experts argue that not every freebie scheme needs to be condemned, the State's major parties are unwilling to disturb the status quo despite knowing that certain schemes do not yield the desired results or are being continued purposelessly.

Parties rework strategy amid increasing acrimony as Kerala race enters final leg

What began as a campaign centred on development, inflation, unemployment has since shifted to conspiracy theories of backroom deal between rival coalitions and cynical identity politics marked by communal overtones; it is shaping up into a direct confrontation between the LDF and UDF



Election trail: (from left) Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, Leader of the Opposition V. D. Satheesan, and BJP Kerala unit president Rajeev Chandrasekhar during poll campaigns. NIRMAL HARINDRAN, PTI



IN FOCUS

Biju Govind
KOZHIKODE

With barely a week remaining before campaigning ends for the Kerala Assembly election, the major political fronts are overhauling their strategies and intensifying their push to win over the electorate for the single-phase polling on April 9. The electoral battle is crystallising into a direct confrontation between the ruling CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF) and an invigorated Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF), with the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) struggling

to muscle in as a third force in the sweepstakes. Against this backdrop, what began as an election focused on development, inflation, and unemployment has since evolved into something far murkier. Conspiracy theories about backroom deals between rival coalitions and cynical identity politics with communal overtones involving outfits such as the SDPI and the Jamaat-e-Islami Hind are now dominating the final leg of electioneering. As campaigning reaches a fever pitch, big names have landed in the State. Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who has already visited Palakkad and Thrissur, is expected to return next week for a final blitz in the southern districts. Ra-

hul Gandhi, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, has electrified the race with a string of charged rallies, while his sister and AICC general secretary, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, is expected to begin her campaign shortly. Rocky start for UDF While the UDF was energised by an unexpected victory in the three-tier local body polls held in December 2025, the coalition has spent much of this campaign firefighting internally over who should be the Chief Ministerial candidate should the UDF come to power. The party lagged behind in releasing its list of candidates; and the public drama surrounding K. Sudhakaran, an MP who put

the party leadership on tenterhooks over his candidature, has taken the shine off the Opposition's charge. The UDF is now attempting to resurrect the Sabarimala gold theft scandal, while balancing it with a manifesto centred on social welfare and financial security, specifically targeting youth and women. LDF's stance However, Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan hit back at Mr. Gandhi over the Sabarimala gold case, questioning how the prime accused, Unnikrishnan Potti, accompanied by senior Congress leaders, was seen with Sonia Gandhi at her residence in Delhi. Meanwhile, the LDF, which began its campaign

relying on the raw political instinct of Mr. Vijayan, is aiming to highlight a decade of continuity with development initiatives and welfare schemes. Yet, the Left Front faces a reckoning as it deals with internal erosion. Dissidents-turned-UDF-backed candidates in Kannur, Palakkad, and Alappuzha are mounting a challenge. Congress leaders, including Mr. Gandhi, are reiterating allegations of a clandestine understanding between the CPI(M) and the BJP. To support this, they point to the lack of progress in investigation in the gold smuggling case. The CPI(M) has rubbished this, while the BJP has dismissed it as a bluff. As for the NDA, the coalition is attempting to

break the traditional two-party dominance by converting its vote share into actual seats, a daunting task that has previously stalled at the finish line. Its leadership is focusing on hard metrics from the Lok Sabha election in 2024 to prove an organic expansion of the party base. FCRA issue The BJP's “minority diplomacy” with the Christian electorate appears desperate to clear the hurdle over the Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA) issue. The proposed amendments have alarmed the Church leadership, forcing the BJP to work double-time to neutralise the fallout in central Kerala and alter negative perceptions.

Khela Hobe: game on as Trinamool fields sportspersons in north Bengal

Shiv Sahay Singh
RAJGANJ/TUFANJANJ

An Asian Games gold medal-winning athlete and a former first-class cricketer who represented Bengal in the Ranji Trophy are the Trinamool Congress candidates taking on Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) nominees in north Bengal. Swapna Barman, the first Indian heptathlete to win an Asian Games gold in 2018 is the Trinamool candidate for the Rajganj Assembly seat in Jalpaiguri district. On Monday, Northeast Frontier Railway authorities formally accepted her resignation and issued her a clearance letter to contest the election. The celebrated athlete, who joined the ruling party weeks before the polls on February 27, says she realises that sports and politics are different disciplines. “Sports is a very different field and cannot be compared to politics. In sports, individual dedication and hard work matters and brings success. In politics, everything is dependent on the will of the people,” Ms. Barman told *The Hindu*. Sports academy The 29-year-old, who hails from Jalpaiguri, is promis-



Swapna Barman and Shib Shankar Paul.



Swapna Barman is contesting from Rajganj; Shib Shankar Paul is contesting from Tufanganj

ing that if elected, she will try and set up a sports academy in her constituency. “I want many Swapna Barman to emerge from North Bengal,” she said. Often seen posing with tea garden workers, Ms. Barman describes herself as “the local daughter who does not need an introduction” and who has been sent by Trinamool Congress chairperson Mamata Banerjee. Hailing from the Rajbangshi community, Ms. Barman grew up in Jalpaiguri and won many laurels, including the prestigious Arjuna Award. “The people in my con-

stituency are very simple, they just want peace and development. I will strive for that,” she said. The athlete is contesting against BJP's Dinesh Sarkar, who has links with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh. The CPI(M) has fielded Kharendranath Roy from the area dotted by tea gardens. Cricket to politics About 150 km from Rajganj is the Tufanganj Assembly seat in Cooch Behar district, where former first-class cricketer Shib Shankar Paul is the election fray on Trinamool ticket. The 46-year-old was a right-arm fast bowler and had represented the Bengal cricket team for several years. He joined the Trinamool on March 16, a day before the party announced can-

didates for the polls. “I prepare for poll campaigns like I used to prepare for a match. I exercise, then I do my homework about the place I am visiting,” said the former cricketer who was also included in India's Test squad during the 2004-05 series against Australia. Mr. Paul says that both cricket and politics do not come easily to anyone. “Playing cricket is very difficult, no one can say they will get these many runs or wickets. Same way politics is also difficult... But I feel happy that I can reach people and understand their problems,” he said. The former bowler says that when he was playing or coaching, he could help only a handful of people, but after joining Trinamool and contesting polls, he hopes that he can come to the aid of the masses. He is contesting against BJP's two-term MLA Malati Rava Roy who has served as a district president of the party. The CPI(M) has fielded Dhananjay Rava. In the past, the Trinamool has fielded several candidates from the Bengali television and film industry, but this time the party has pinned hopes on sportspersons to revive its prospects in north Bengal.

BJP's Assam poll manifesto promises UCC, land rights

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Tuesday released its manifesto for the April 9 Assam Assembly election, promising to work towards implementing the Uniform Civil Code (UCC), protecting the land, heritage, and dignity of indigenous people, and pushing its development agenda. Releasing the 31-point “Sankalp Patra” at the party's State headquarters in Guwahati, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman highlighted Assam's “transformative change over the last 10 years”, which, she said, had fuelled economic growth of the State and the rest of the northeastern region. Among the main promises are the implementation of the Immigrants (Expulsion from Assam) Act, 1950, to expedite detection and deportation of illegal immigrants; removing encroachment by illegal immigrants; and granting land rights to citizens. Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said the manifesto emphasised the protection of land and its genuine citizens. “We will strengthen the legislative protections to preserve the



Nirmala Sitharaman

civilisation, heritage, and rights of the people of Assam by working towards the implementation of the UCC, excluding the Sixth Schedule areas and tribal communities, while ensuring the traditional rights of ethnic communities,” he said. The BJP promised to formulate an effective Act to end “love jihad”. Further, it promised to ensure education for all, including free education from KG to PG for the economically weaker sections, build world-class institutions, and expand the teacher workforce. “We will strengthen the economic independence of the women of Assam by increasing the monthly assistance under the Orunodoi Scheme to ₹3,000 (from the current ₹1,250) in a phased manner,” the manifesto read.

INBRIEF



SEBI fines EliteCon ₹51.2 cr. for alleged insider trading

Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) fined Elite Con International, a cigarette-maker, ₹51 crore and banned it from the securities market for allegedly inflating the price of the company’s stock and dumping them on retail investors, gaining ₹51.2 crore, according to an order released on March 31. The interim order was passed against noticees Vipin Sharma, the company’s promoter, Pawan Kumar Ray, a non-promoter and three others.

Mindspace buys Chennai office space for ₹2,541 crore

Mindspace Business Parks REIT, owner of quality Grade A office assets,has acquired 100% equity shareholding in Sycamore Properties Private Ltd. and Content Properties Private Ltd., comprising 2.6 million sq.ft. at Commerzone Pallikaranai, located on the Pallavaram-Thoraipakkam Road (PTR) in Chennai, for ₹2,541 crore. The board of the manager to Mindspace Business Parks REIT has approved the transaction and preferential issuance of up to ₹675 crore.

Corona buys Wokadine brand from Dr. Reddy’s in India

Corona Remedies has acquired Wokadine brand from Dr. Reddy’s Laboratories in India. The acquisition, effective March 30, marks the company’s entry into the ₹648 crore Povidone Iodine market in India. Wokadine is ranked number two in the market and the brand holds strong potential for accelerated growth under its stewardship, Corona said on Monday. The company said the acquisition will be fully funded through internal accruals and cash.

IHC to buy Sammaan stake for \$1 billion

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Sammaan Capital Ltd., formerly IndiaBulls Housing Finance Ltd, said West Asia’s IHC, with a market cap of \$232 billion, via affiliate, Avenir Investment RSC Ltd. will become the promoter of Sammaan Capital Ltd. by acquiring 41.5% stake via a preferential allotment of equity shares and warrants.

Sammaan Capital said it received an initial tranche of \$5,652 crore (\$600 million) towards the allotment of equity shares and warrants, with an additional ₹3,198 crore (\$338 million) to be received within 18 months upon conversion of the warrants into fully paid equity shares.

Avenir will work on concluding the open offer within 30 days, which was



IHC, through Avenir, will hold 63.3% in Sammaan Capital.

announced at ₹139 per fully paid equity share of Sammaan Capital. Upon completion of the open and assuming full uptake in the open offer, IHC, through Avenir will hold 63.3% stake in Sammaan Capital.

“Sammaan Capital enters this new chapter from a position of structural strength, with full capacity and intent to grow,” the company said.

Government says 30 mineral blocks made operational in FY2025-26

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

In a first for India, the Ministry of Mines informed that 30 mineral blocks have been made operational in a single financial year viz. FY2025-26.

Essential to note, most of the blocks made operational are those of limestone followed by iron ore.

Majority of these standalone limestone blocks are located in Gujarat, that is, four blocks, followed by Madhya Pradesh with three blocks, Rajasthan with two, Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh



Taking off: After limestone, most of the blocks are those of iron ore. (Picture for representational purpose only).

and Assam one block each. Iron ore blocks made operational originate in Goa (four blocks) whilst Madhya Pradesh, Odisha

IndiGo fiasco: DGCA head shunted out; airline names CEO

Move comes amid scrutiny of regulator’s oversight with queries on how it allowed IndiGo to expand winter schedule sans checking pilot availability

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

Three months after widespread flight cancellations by IndiGo disrupted air travel across India, the Centre moved out the head of aviation safety regulator even as the airline named a new chief executive.

The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet said Faiz Kidwai, Director General of the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), will be shifted to the Department of Personnel and Training. He will be succeeded by Vir Vikram Yadav, Additional Secretary, Environment Ministry.



New vista: Willie Walsh previously served as CEO of British Airways and International Airlines Group. REUTERS FILE

The move comes amid scrutiny of the regulator’s oversight with questions raised over how the DGCA allowed IndiGo to expand winter flight schedule without adequately assessing pilot availability. On the same day, Inter-

Globe Aviation Ltd., IndiGo’s parent, named Willie Walsh CEO. Mr. Walsh, Director General of the International Air Transport Association (IATA), is likely to take charge by August 3 after his IATA term ends.

‘March India diesel export to SE Asia at 7-year high on war’

Reuters
SINGAPORE

India’s diesel exports to Southeast Asia surged to the highest in more than seven years in March, shipping data showed, as traders pivoted supply to cover short positions and refiners cashed in on higher profits in Asia caused by the U.S.-Israeli war with Iran.

The surge in exports could boost spot sale mar-

gins for Indian refiners who have purchased large volumes of prompt Russian crude to replace Middle East supply disrupted by the war.

About 1 million metric tonne (7.45 million barrels) of diesel have been shipped on this trade route, according to data from analytics firm Kpler and three trade sources, with around half of the volumes bound for Singapore. Around 90% of these

volumes were shipped by Reliance Industries, Kpler data showed, operator of the world’s largest refining complex.

Reliance did not immediately respond to a Reuters request for comment.

Supply pivots Traders tapped India’s diesel supply for Southeast Asia and Australia after the Middle East conflict disrupted crude supplies to Asia, leading refineries to

LPG vessel arrives at Mumbai port

Snehal Mutha
MUMBAI

The Indian flagged LPG carrier, BW TYR vessel, arrived Mumbai port on Tuesday, crossing the Strait of Hormuz, as per a ship tracker website. It is among the two LPG carriers that departed from Dubai-Ras Al Khaima on Friday; the second carrier is BW ELM.

BW TYR is an LPG Tanker built in 2008, sailing under the flag of India.

The LPG carriers – BW TYR and BW ELM – carrying about 94,000 tonne, safely crossed Strait of Hormuz and moved towards Indian coast, as per an official statement.

According to the Marine Traffic website, the tanker marks the latest Indian-flagged vessel to transit the Strait, followed by four other LNG tankers, namely Shivalik, Nanda Devi, Pine Gas, and Jag Vasant. BW Elm is expected to



Cargo ships near the Strait of Hormuz. (For representational purpose only)

arrive in New Mangalore on April 1.

As of March 29, the Indian Government said there were 18 Indian-flagged vessels with 485 Indian seafarers in the Gulf.

“Shipping through the Strait has largely halted amid the conflict, with Iran permitting passage only to “non-hostile vessels” coordinating with its authorities,” as per the statement. (With inputs from PTI and Marine traffic website)

War can cut 1% point off India’s FY27 GDP growth projection: EY

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India’s real GDP growth for the next fiscal could erode by around 1 percentage point, while retail inflation could rise by about 1.5 percentage points from their baseline estimates if the Middle East conflict persists through the next fiscal, an EY report said.

The EY Economy Watch report said several sectors, including employment-intensive sectors like textiles, paints, chemicals, fertilizers, cement and tires, could be directly impacted. Any reduction in employment or incomes in these sectors may further dampen aggregate demand. As a result, supply and demand conditions may be affected by global oil market disturbances.

It said the Indian economy, which imports nearly 90% of its crude oil requirements, is also highly dependent on imports of natural gas and fertilizers, and is particularly vulnerable to such external shocks, with the adverse effects likely to cascade across multiple sectors through strong forward and backward linkages with crude oil and energy.

The conflict significantly disrupted global crude oil and energy markets by affecting supply, storage, transportation and prices. Even if the conflict is resolved in the near term, some of the disruptions may take considerable time to normalise, it said.

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-tender Notice
No. 76 of 2025-26 (Open)-Engg/DDU
On line (through e-tendering) for the following work is invited by DRM/Engg/DDU for and on behalf of the President of India from experienced and financially as well as technically sound contractors including those enlisted with the Railway, CPWD, BSNL, MES, PWD and other public sector undertakings: - (1) Name of work with its location: No. 76 of 2025-26 (Open)-Engg/DDU Replacing of plate girder by PSC slab and jacking for Br. No. 677.697 & 698 under ADEN/2DDU. (2) Advertised Value : 102912418.09. (3) Earnest Money: 664600.00. (4) Closing Date & time for submission of e-tender: 17.04.2026, Up-to 12.00 hrs. (5) Website particulars of e-tendering: www.irops.gov.in
Divisional Railway Manager
East Central Railway/
PR/2007/DDU/ENGG/T/25-26/28

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE
NO.- ECR-CAO-C-N-40-25-26
E-tender is invited on behalf of the president of india for the under mentioned work:- (1) Name of work with it's location: Supplying & Erection / Launching of FOB at Rambhadrpur Station and completion of other leftover works between RBZ-HYT TLWA stations in connection with SPJ-DBG Doubling. (2) Approx. cost of the work of: Rs. 16,47,00,649.53. (3) Bid Security Amount: Rs. 32,94,00,00.00. (4) Date and time for closing of tender:- 17.04.2026 at 14.30 hrs. (5) Website particular, Notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and addressed of the office from where the tender form be purchased etc. : The above E-Tender, E-Tendering document alongwith full information is available on website i.e. <http://www.irops.gov.in>. Note:In case of any discrepancies found in tender notice, English version will be final. Tenderers are requested to visit the website <http://www.irops.gov.in> atleast 15 days before last date of closing for latest corrigendum/corrections etc in response to this E-Tender
CAO/Con/North EC Rly.
MHX, Patna
PR/2008/CN/NIM/HX/CONST/17/25-26/36

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-tender Notice
e-tender is invited on behalf of the President of India for the under mentioned work:- (1) E-Tender No.: ECR-CAO-C-S-ETEN-DOS-06 in Two packet system, (2) Name of Work: Construction of New B. G. Line between East Outer Cabin (EOC) and Fly Over Cabin (FOC) for DDU Bypass Line (2.666 KM). (3) Approx Cost of the Work (in Rs.): 11,58,07,656.86, Bid Security: 23,16,200.00. (4) Period of Work Completion: 06 (Six) Months. Date and time for closing of tender: 18.04.2026 at 13.00 Hrs. Any e-tender which is sent by Post/Courier/Fax or by hand will not be accepted. All such manual submission of tender, even if it is on firm's letter pad or received in time, will not be accepted. The above e-tender document along with full information is available on website <http://www.irops.gov.in>. Note: In case of any discrepancies found in tender notice, English version will be final. Tenderers are requested to visit the website <http://www.irops.gov.in> at least 15 days before last date of closing, for latest corrigendum /corrections etc in connection with this e-tender.
Dy. Chief Engineer(Con.)
East Central Railway/Dehari-on-con
PR/2010/CONSTRUCTION DOS/CONST/17/25-26/36

THE HINDU
Air Surcharge as applicable:
New Delhi - Rs. 15/-
Port Blair - Rs. 20/-
OUTSOURCING OF OPERATION AND MAINTENANCE
E-Procurement Tender Notice
No. R1 Outsourcing.TMachines dated 26-03-2026 E-Tenders are invited by the undersigned for the following works: Tender No.: TM. Outsourcing.TMachines. Brief Description of the work: Outsourcing of Operation and Maintenance of 25 nos. Track Machines for a period of two years in North East Frontier Railway. Tender Value: ₹18,34,60,385.04/-, E-Tender will be closed at 15:00 hrs. & opening at 15:30 hrs. on 20-04-2026. The complete information with the tender document of above e-tender will be available upto 14.30 hrs. on 20-04-2026 on website www.irops.gov.in
Dy CE/TMC/Malgaoon
NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
Serving Customers With A Smile
SELECTION OF THE SERVICE PROVIDER FOR DESIGNATED HEALTHCARE FACILITIES
Tender No.: H-PC-LAB-02-2025-RT; date: 26-03-2026. E-tenders are invited by the undersigned for the following work: Name of Work: Selection of the Service Provider for establishment, operation and maintenance of diagnostic laboratories to provide diagnostic services at the designated healthcare facilities of Northeast Frontier Railway based on Central Reference Laboratory, Hub & Spoke Model integrated through Laboratory Information Management System (LIMS). Advertised Value: ₹47,66,631.40. Earnest Money: ₹8,38,500.00. E-tenders will be closed at 17:00 hrs. on 20-04-2026. The complete information with the tender document of above e-tender will be available in website www.irops.gov.in
Medical Director, Central Hospital, Malgaon
NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
Serving Customers with a smile

SOUTHERN RAILWAY
MEDICAL DEPARTMENT
Empanelment of Honorary Visiting Specialists at Southern Railway Headquarters Hospital, Perambur, Chennai -23.
Honorary Visiting Specialists are required in the following Specialities at Southern Railway Headquarters Hospital, Perambur, Chennai-23.
S.No Speciality No. of Vacant Post Qualification and Experience
1. Orthopedician 1 Specialist:
1) PG degree with 3 years of experience
2) PG Diploma in Orthopedics with Five year experience
Note: The appointment of Honorary Visiting Specialist is contractual and does not confer any right for regularization / regular appointment in Railways. Detailed Terms and Conditions governing the empanelment is available on the Southern Railway website www.sr.indianrailways.gov.in/currentevents.
Those interested may apply to The Medical Director, Southern Railway Headquarters Hospital, Perambur, Chennai-600023 along with Bio-Data of Birth Certificate. The Application should reach the office of Medical Director, Southern Railway Headquarters Hospital, perambur, Chennai - 600023 on or before 15/04/2026
Medical Director,
Railway Hospital, Ayanavaram, Chennai - 23.

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-TENDER
E-Tenders are invited for execution of the following works by Divisional Railway Manager (Engg), E.C. Railway, Dhanbad:- (1) E-Tender No.: 386-DHN-2025-26. Name of the work with its location & completion period : Provision of water treatment plant at RNQ under ADEN/RNQ. 12 (Twelve) Months. Approx. cost of work (in Rs.): 96,47,535.63. (2) E-Tender No.: 387-DHN-2025-26, Name of the work with its location & completion period : Supply of portion and welding including supervision for welding of rail joints by SKV method in connection with various track renewal and repair works under ADEN/CPJ & ADEN/RNQ in the jurisdiction of Sr. DENA/DNA. 06 (Six) Months. Approx. cost of work (in Rs.): 1,20,30,926.28. Earnest Money (in Rs.): Earnest Money is applicable as shown in <http://www.irops.gov.in>. Date & Time for closing and opening of e-tender : Date of closing of e-tender at 12-00 hours on 21.04.2026. Date of opening of e-tender from 12:30 hrs. on 21.04.2026. Website particulars : <http://www.irops.gov.in> No manual tender will be accepted against e-tendering.
Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering),
East Central Railway/Dhanbad.
PR/2006/DHN/ENGG/T/25-26/36

MSME TECHNOLOGY DEVELOPMENT CENTRE CHENNAI
Government of India Autonomous Body
CFTI, 65/1, G.S.T. Road, Guindy, Chennai - 600 032
3 Weekend Online Training Program on Government Certified Professional Course on Certified Meta Ads & Social Media Marketing (Facebook & Instagram Ads)
Date : 11th, 12th, 18th, 19th, 25th April 2026 Time: 2.00 p.m. to 6.00 p.m.
Contents : Social Media Marketing Training (Facebook, Instagram & Meta Ads), Facebook Organic Marketing (Page Setup, Optimization Guidelines, Content Strategy), Meta Business Suite, Posting Analytics, Engagement, Content Calendar Creation) Meta Ads (Ad Account Creation, Pixel Setup, Campaign Structure, Live Campaign Implementation), Best Performing Creative Formats (Static, Carousel, Reels, Collection), Branding Principles (Thumbnails, Typography, Color Psychology), Creative Hooks & Ad Copy Writing Techniques (Headlines, CTA), Instagram Marketing (Profile Setup, Branding, Optimization), Photography & Design Building, Audience Retention, Boosted Posts Vs Ads Manager, Ad Policies & Best Practices, Monetization & Brand Deals, Analytics & Insights, Personal Branding & Storytelling, Trends, Tools You will learn ChatGPT, Rytr, Grammarly, Social Bee, Linktree
COURSE FEE: Rs. 6,000 (incl.GST) Fees to be paid throu' online www.cftichennai.in
Account No : 39366874350, IFSC Code : SBIN0000956, DIRECTOR, MSME TDC
For Details: Mob : 95000 34831 / 96772 90237 / 72005 26886
Contact Ph : 044 22501529 Ext : 27 E-Mail: msmetdc@cftichennai.in www.cftichennai.in
GOVT OF INDIA CERTIFICATE WILL BE ISSUED TO SUCCESSFUL CANDIDATES

North Eastern Railway
TENDER NOTICE NO.-53 DT 30.03.2026
Principal Chief Material Manager, North Eastern Railway, Gorakhpur 273012 and on behalf of The President of India, invites tenders through e-procurement system for the supply for the supply of the following items. Complete description of the item and other condition are available on www.irops.gov.in
Item No Tender Number Due On Brief Description of Stores Qty.
1 29265186 12/05/2026 Underground Railway Jelly Filled 6 Quad cable etc. 1298.97 Kilometre
2 26255166A 29/04/2026 Designing, Manufacture, supplying etc. 150 sets.
3 28260890 28/04/2026 Polyvastra Bed Sheet Bleached White etc. 10900 Nos.
4 29265069 27/04/2026 Supply of LOW MAINTENANCE LEAD etc. 1600 Nos.
5 28260914 22/04/2026 Fire Retardant curtain fabric etc. 19226 Mtrs.
6 29261046 21/04/2026 LED Signal Lamps For subsidiary colour light etc. 1401 Nos.
7 22250231 21/04/2026 Silent Block for Anchor Link of BG coaches etc 13458 Nos.
8 22260045 20/04/2026 Densified thermal bonded polyester block etc 8023 Nos.
9 22261837 16/04/2026 Lateral Damper (200 Kg) for DEMU etc. 1594 Nos.
10 22251415B 22/04/2026 Bogie centre pivot top for casnub bogie etc. 2030 Nos.
Principal Chief Material Manager
Gorakhpur
CPRO-S-99
"DO NOT TRAVEL WITH INFELAMMABLE ARTICLE IN TRAIN"

JERUSALEM

Israel military says four soldiers were killed in southern Lebanon



AFP The Israeli military said on Tuesday four soldiers had been killed in combat in southern Lebanon where its forces are clashing with Hezbollah. A military statement named three soldiers from the same battalion who “fell during combat” and a separate statement said another soldier had died in the same incident. AFP

TEHRAN

U.S.-Israel strikes targeted major pharmaceutical company: Tehran



AFP U.S.-Israeli air strikes on Tuesday hit Tofigh Daru Research & Engineering Company, one of the largest pharmaceutical companies in Iran which produces anaesthetic and cancer drugs, the Iranian government said. Iran has long faced chronic shortages of medicines, partly due to UN sanctions imposed over it. AFP

GENEVA

Over 2 lakh people fled Lebanon for Syria in March, says UNHCR



AFP More than 2 lakh people have fled Lebanon for Syria since fighting resumed a month ago between Israeli forces and Lebanon's Hezbollah movement, the United Nations' refugee agency, UNHCR, said on Tuesday. “The vast majority — nearly 1.8 lakh — are Syrians, including refugees who had fled Syria in the past,” it added. AFP

NAYPYIDAW

Min Aung Hlaing, Myanmar junta chief, elected as Vice-President



AFP Myanmar's junta chief, Min Aung Hlaing, was elected Vice-President by the lower house on Tuesday, parliamentary officials said. Parliament elects three Vice-Presidents, one of whom is then chosen as President. The vote to decide which of the three will be elevated to the presidency is expected later this week. AFP

Iran has ‘necessary will’ to end war, but seeking guarantees: President

Iran's five-point counterproposal to 15-point U.S. plan calls for ending the ‘aggression’; attack on Isfahan, which hosts nuclear enrichment site, created a massive fireball; strike on oil tanker caused a fire, which officials say ‘did not result in an oil spill’

Agence France-Presse
Associated Press
TEHRAN/DUBAI



Caught in crosshairs: Damage to the Kuwait-flagged Al-Salmi oil tanker, following a reported Iranian strike on Tuesday. REUTERS

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian said on Tuesday his country had the “necessary will” to end the ongoing war with Israel and the United States, but was seeking guarantees that the conflict would not be repeated. “We possess the necessary will to end this conflict, provided that essential conditions are met — especially the guarantees required to prevent repetition of the aggression,” Mr.

Pezeshkian said in a phone conversation with the President of the European Council, according to a

statement from his office, reiterating a key demand of Tehran's. Responding to a 15-point

U.S. plan for ending the war last week, Iran issued a five-point counterproposal that also called for ending the “aggression” and establishing a mechanism guaranteeing that neither Israel nor the United States would return to war, Iranian media reported. “The solution to normalising the situation is the cessation of their aggressive attacks,” Mr. Pezeshkian said on Tuesday. U.S. strikes hit a city on Tuesday that is home to one of Iran's main nuclear sites, sending a massive fireball into the sky, and

Tehran attacked a fully loaded Kuwaiti oil tanker in the Persian Gulf. An Iranian drone hit a Kuwaiti oil tanker in waters off the United Arab Emirates city of Dubai, sparking a blaze that was later put out, the Dubai Media Office said. Authorities said there was no oil spill. U.S.-Israeli strikes also killed four persons, wounded 26 and damaged the Grand Husseiniya, a Shia Muslim mosque in northwest Iranian city of Zanjan. Local media added that “parts of dome and minarets were damaged”.

China, Pak. outline 5-point plan to end West Asia war

Agence France-Presse
BEIJING

China and Pakistan called on Tuesday for an immediate end to the war in the West Asia, and for peace talks as soon as possible, as they agreed to boost their cooperation on Iran. The two countries outlined a joint initiative “for restoring peace and stability in the Gulf and Middle East region”, after a visit from senior Pakistani officials to Beijing. Both countries have sought to mediate in the West Asia to prevent the conflict from escalating, with Islamabad saying it is ready to host “meaningful talks” between the United States and Iran.



Wang Yi

Pakistani Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar met his Chinese counterpart Wang Yi and agreed to “strengthen strategic communication and coordination on the Iran situation and ... make new efforts towards advocating for peace”, Beijing said. Mr. Dar's Ministry later said the two sides had

agreed on a five-point plan, starting with the “immediate cessation of hostilities” and the “start of peace talks as soon as possible”. On talks, which the United States claims are ongoing but Iran denies, the governments said dialogue and diplomacy were “the only viable option to resolve conflicts”. “China and Pakistan support the relevant parties in initiating talks, with all parties committing to peaceful resolution of disputes, and refraining from the use or the threat of use of force during peace talks,” it added. The plan also calls for an end to attacks on civilians and non-military targets.

‘We have no kings,’ chant protesters as anti-Trump movement expands

Anisha Dutta
NEW YORK



Massive outrage: Demonstrators congregating at the State Capitol during a ‘No Kings’ protest in St. Paul, Minnesota. REUTERS

A slogan touted as a warning against rising authoritarianism under U.S. President Donald Trump's administration has, over the past year, grown into one of the largest protest movements in recent American history with millions across the country and in cities abroad, taking to the streets on March 28 under the banner: “No Kings.” “IN AMERICA, WE HAVE NO KINGS,” declares the website of the ‘No Kings’ movement, a loose but rapidly expanding coalition opposing President Donald Trump, in a message that has now become a rallying cry. It goes on to accuse the administration of unleashing “masked secret police”, pursuing “an illegal, catastrophic war putting us in danger and driving up our costs”, and undermining civil liberties. “Power belongs to the people — not to wannabe kings or their billionaire cronies.” White House spokesperson Abigail Jackson characterised them as the product of “leftist funding networks” with little real public support. The “only people who care about these Trump Derangement Therapy Sessions are the reporters who are paid to cover them,” Ms. Jackson said in a statement. According to the organisers, Saturday's demonstrations, the third nationwide mobilisation since Mr. Trump's re-election in January 2025, were the largest yet with an estimated eight million people participating in nearly every major U.S. city, alongside solidarity protests in Paris, London, Lisbon and Rome among other cities. The turnout surpassed earlier waves in June and October

last year, which drew roughly five million and seven million participants, respectively, according to the organisers. Grassroots movement ‘No Kings’ is a coalition-driven protest movement primarily driven by progressive, anti-authoritarian organisations, including Indivisible, 50501, Move-On, Public Citizen, the American Civil Liberties Union, and the National Action Network. The groups also bring in a broad range of partner organisations, labor unions, legal organisations such as the American Civil Liberties Union, and advocacy groups such as the Movement for Black Lives. Their stated aim, according to organisers, is to “safeguard democracy from an authoritarian” through “organised, non-violent, insistent people power”. That message appears to be resonating across a wide spectrum of Americans. While immigration enforcement has emerged as a central flashpoint, the protests reflect a convergence of grievances: the administration's military posture abroad, especially its war in Iran; rising living costs; alleged voter suppression; and the rollback of civil rights protections.

The symbolic centre of Saturday's protests was the Twin Cities region — Minneapolis and St. Paul — where tensions over immigration enforcement have been particularly acute after residents stood up to the surge of federal immigration agents the Trump administration sent into the region earlier this year and after the death of two residents, Renee Good and Alex Pretti, who were killed while observing activities by Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE). The flagship rally drew tens of thousands to the State Capitol in St. Paul. Senator Bernie Sanders addressed the crowd alongside actor-activist Jane Fonda and musicians Joan Baez and Maggie Rogers. Later, Bruce Springsteen performed a song titled ‘Streets of Minneapolis’, sharply critical of immigration enforcement policies. A pre-recorded message from actor Robert De Niro was also played at the rally. The actor said he wakes up “depressed” by the political climate but felt hopeful seeing millions mobilise. He also praised Minnesotans for “running ICE out of town” — a claim that organisers say reflects the growing resistance to federal enforcement efforts. Protesters held up ef-

figies of Mr. Trump, Vice President J.D. Vance and other officials in the administration, calling for their ousting and arrest. In Washington, hundreds marched past the Lincoln Memorial and into the National Mall, holding signs that read “Put down the crown, clown” and “Regime change begins at home”. Demonstrators rang bells, played drums and chanted “No kings.” In New York City, thousands packed Times Square and marched through Midtown Manhattan, forcing police to shut down major streets. Demonstrators carried placards reading “No kings, no crowns” and “Democracy, not dynasty,” while chanting slogans. The scale of turnout likely exceeded October's protest, when more than 100,000 people gathered across the city's five boroughs. Donna Lieberman, executive director of the New York Civil Liberties Union, said during a news conference that Mr. Trump and his supporters want people to be afraid to protest. “They want us to be afraid that there's nothing we can do to stop them,” she said. “But you know what? They are wrong — dead wrong.” Critics say the administration's actions have tested constitutional norms and intensified fears of executive overreach. The “No Kings” movement has positioned itself not merely as a protest campaign but also as a sustained resistance effort. The organisers announced a “mass call” on March 31 with leaders and fellow local activists to celebrate the historic mobilisation and dig into what comes next. (Anisha Dutta is a journalist based in New York)

GUJARAT INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION
(A Govt of Gujarat Undertaking)
O/o the Superintending Engineer (SG)
Plot No. C5/101, Char Rasta, GIDC, Vapi - 396 195.
E-TENDER NOTICE No. 20 of 2025-2026
The tender for the work having cost of Rs. 660.36 crore is invited by office of the Superintending Engineer (SG), G.I.D.C., Vapi under jurisdiction of the Executive Engineer, GIDC, Vapi through Tender for online works. The tender for Online work can be upload - download on website www.nprocure.com. The detailed tender notice can be seen in GIDC office notice board / GIDC website www.gidc.gujarat.gov.in. Right to reject the tender without assigning any reasons thereof are reserved by G.I.D.C., which will be binding to all bidders. Please stay touring web site www.nprocure.com for any corrigendum/ addendum / modification till last date of receipt.
SD/-
Superintending Engineer (SG)
G.I.D.C., Vapi.
No. INF/Valsad/ 1041/26

BENGALURU SOUTH CITY CORPORATION
Office of the Executive Engineer, Jayanagara Division,
No.44, 18th Main road, 39th Cross, Jayanagar
4th T block, Bengaluru-560041
No: EE/BSCC/JN/TEND/06/2025-26 Date: 27-03-2026
SHORT TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION
(Two Cover System)
(Through GOK KPP Portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> only)
The Executive Engineer, Jayanagara Division, BSCC, invites tenders on behalf the Commissioner, BSCC, Bengaluru from eligible contractors registered in Greater Bengaluru Authority (Bengaluru South City Corporation) Or equivalent registration with KPWD/CPWD/Railways/MES or any State Government Organizations for the constructions of work detailed in the table below.

Sl. No.	Name of the work
1.	Improvements to roads, drains, Culverts in Kaveramma Temple, 2nd cross road, Byrasandra and surrounding area in Ward No. 182 Byrasandra. Estimate Cost: ₹. 200.00 Lakhs, EMD: ₹. 3,00,000/-
2.	Comprehensive development of roads, drains and other developmental works JP Nagara 1st Phase ITI Layout, Shakambarinagara and Surrounding area in Ward No.186 Shakambarinagara Ward. Estimate Cost: ₹. 210.00 Lakhs, EMD: ₹. 3,15,000/-

Calendar of Events : (1) Tender must be submitted online through KPP portal on or before **10-04-2026, 4:00 pm**. (2) Pre-Bid Meeting will be held on office of the Chief Engineer, Jayanagar Zone (Zone-1), Bengaluru South City Corporation, 9th Main, 9th Cross, Jayanagar 2nd Block, Bengaluru-560011 on **07-04-2026 at 3:00 pm**. (3) Technical Bids will be Opened on **13-04-2026 at 4:05 pm**. (4) Financial bids will be Opened on **15-04-2026 by 4:05 pm**.
SD/-
Executive Engineer, Jayanagara Division
Bengaluru South City Corporation

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www.thehindugroup.in/subscribe

The Andhra Pradesh Mineral Development Corporation Limited
Door No.294/1D, 100 feet Road (Tadigadapa to Enikepadu Road),
Kanuru, Vijayawada-521137, Andhra Pradesh, India
Tel: +91-866-2429999, Fax: +91-866-2429977 Email: contracts-ho@apmdc.in
SHORT TERM TENDER NOTICE
Tender No:APMDC/HO/P&C/Science Lab Equipment-APMDC
-DAV Model School at Suliyari/2025-26/1, Dt: 01.04.2026
APMDC invites Short Term E-tender from reputed Agencies for “Supply of Laboratory Setup Accessories to APMDC - DAV Model School at Suliyari Coal Project, Madhya Pradesh”. For more information on the eligibility criteria, tender fees, timelines and other details, please visit e-procurement website of GoAP www.tender.aeprocurement.gov.in or APMDC website (www.apmdc.ap.gov.in). The Tender document is available for downloading from **01.04.2026** and the last date for bid submission is **15.04.2026 by 17:00 Hrs.**
Sd/-
Place: Vijayawada Managing Director
Date: 01.04.2026 The A.P. Mineral Development Corporation Limited
DIPR 4946PP/CL, DL31/03/2026

MUNICIPAL CORPORATION BHARATPUR
Ref :MCB/Technical /2025-26/25728 Date: 25.03.2026
NOTICE INVITING E-TENDERS -42/2025-26
Nagar Nigam Bharatpur invites Single-stage Two Part (envelope) Online unconditional open competitive bids through www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in from eligible bidders Nagar Nigam Bharatpur and “A” & “AA” Class in any Central/State/ Government/semi Government organization/Contractors for the work. The document can be seen and downloaded from the website <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> and www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in. Bids are to be submitted online in electronic format as per schedule given below:

Number of Work	01 Work
Name of Work	Construction of Open and Box Drain from Vimal Kunj Tiraha to Pushpattiya Main Drain Near Pani Ki Tanki via Chandwari Nagla
Cost of Work	439.60 Lacs.
Bid Download start date and Time from	From 27.03.2026, at 10.00AM to
Website http://www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in	21.04.2026 upto 06.00 PM
Bid Upload end date and time on Website http://www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in	21.04.2026 Upto 06.00 PM
Pre-bid Meeting Date and Time	06.04.2026 at 11.00AM Venue:- The Municipal Corporation Bharatpur
Submission of Document Physically/ Tender Cost/RISL Fee UTR Slip	22.04.2026 upto 02.00 PM
Technical Bid Opening Date and Time	22.04.2026 at 3.00 PM
Financial Bid Opening Date and Time	Will be intimated later to technically responsive bidders.

UBN is: DLB2526WSOB40361
Raj.Samwad/C/25/23583 **Commissioner**

BENGALURU WEST CITY CORPORATION
Office of the Executive Engineer,
Mahalakshmiapuram Division, 12th Main, 11th Cross,
West of Chord Road, BWCC, Bengaluru.
No: EE/MLP/TEND/E-PROC/18/2025-26 Date: 31-03-2026
SHORT TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION
(Two Cover System) (Through GOK KPP Portal only)
Tenders on item rate basis are invited by the Executive Engineer, Mahalakshmiapuram Division, BWCC, Bengaluru for the work detailed below from the registered Contractors of BWCC or equivalent registration with CPWD / KPWD / Railways / MES / BBMP or any State Government Organizations.
(Standard Tender Document - KW-1, KW-2 KW-3 & KW-4)

Sl. No.	Name of the Work
1	Improvements to Roads and Drains at Vivekananda Park Surrounding Area and Ward Limits Roads in Nagapura Ward No. 49. (Call-2) - Approximated Amount Put to Tender (Rs. in Lakhs): 205.92, EMD Amount (Rs. in Lakhs): 3.09

Calendar of Events: 1) Tender documents may be downloaded from the GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Website: <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> from **02-04-2026 after 16.30 Hours**. 2) Last Date for Receipt of Queries: **06-04-2026 upto 15.00 Hours**. 3) Pre Bid Meeting will be held on **06-04-2026 at 15.30 Hours**. 4) Last Date for Uploading the Filled Proposals is **13-04-2026 upto 16.00 Hours**. 5) Date of Opening of Technical Proposals is **15-04-2026 after 11.00 Hours through KPP Portal**. Further details can be had from the above office.
SD/- Executive Engineer
Mahalakshmiapuram Division, BWCC.

Suryavanshi should be fast-tracked like Tendulkar, says Kumble



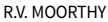
‘If we had lost, the narrative would have been that I’m a bad captain’



‘Pant has got the best people he
could ever have around him’



‘Every time I’ve coached a side, there has been pressure on me’



Cool Connolly takes Kings across the line against plucky Titans

We executed the plans really well: Parag

CM
Y
K

INBRIEF



Advani clinches maiden National 9-ball pool crown

Pankaj Advani added another feather to his cap by winning his maiden National 9-ball pool title in Ludhiana on Tuesday. In the final, the PSPB star, who has 28 World titles in billiards and snooker, outplayed Nitin Sharma of Chandigarh 11-6 in the race-to-11 affair. Advani's compatriot S. Shrikrishna beat Karnataka's Kushal Chandrashekar 7-2 in the third place playoff.

Priya progresses to the 60kg quarterfinals

Priya won her opening bout to advance to the women's 60kg quarterfinals, while Jadumani Singh made an early exit in the men's 55kg category at the Asian boxing championships in Ulaanbaatar on Tuesday. Priya beat Kazakhstan's Rimma Volosstenko 5-0 and set up a last-eight clash with second-seeded Chengyu Yang of China. Jadumani lost 2-3 to third-seeded Japanese Rui Yamaguchi in 55kg.



ASF honour for Abhay, Anahat and Indian boys team

India's Abhay Singh has been declared outstanding Men's Player of the Year 2025 by the Asian Squash Federation (ASF), while Anahat Singh was selected for the top honours in the junior girls' section. The Indian boys team, which clinched bronze at the 2025 World Junior Team Championships in Egypt, was named for the men's team award, according to the awardees list released by ASF on Tuesday. Indian players last featured on the ASF annual awards list in 2022 when Saurav Ghosal and Joshna Chinappa bagged the men's and women's players' honours.

Manika posts win; Sreeja goes down in ITTF World Cup

Manika Batra and Sreeja Akula had contrasting outings in the ITTF World Cup 2026 in Macau on Tuesday. World No. 47 Manika posted a 11-7, 11-2, 14-16, 5-11, 11-6 win over World No. 42 Lily Zhang of the USA in her final group-stage match while the 44th-ranked Sreeja went down to Portugal's World No. 48 Fu Yu 11-8, 9-11, 13-15, 8-11. Sreeja will play Wang Manyu of China on Wednesday.

UP Prometheans latest team to join UTT

Ultimate Table Tennis (UTT) will have a new team in Season 7 with the inclusion of UP Prometheans. The upcoming season, scheduled in July in Goa, will have now seven teams and the number of ties have been increased to 24 from 23 in the last two seasons. Prometheans will also compete in Dream UTT Juniors, an initiative by the Dream Sports Foundation and UTT.

FIFA boss Infantino attends Iran friendly in Turkiye

FIFA president Gianni Infantino attended a friendly in Turkiye between Iran and Costa Rica on Tuesday. The Iranian federation has said it is "negotiating" with FIFA to relocate the country's World Cup matches from USA to Mexico.

Ghana sacks coach Addo 10 weeks before FIFA World Cup

Ghana said on Tuesday it has dismissed coach Otto Addo, hours after a friendly defeat to Germany and just over 70 days until the World Cup. Ghana lost 1-2 in Stuttgart on Monday. It was a fourth defeat in a row for Addo's side.

LIVE TELECAST

▼

IFL: Sony Sports Ten 5 & FanCode, 4 & 6.30 p.m.
IPL: Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 7.30 p.m.

Blue Tigers delight the faithful with a great win

Australian import Williams marks his India debut with a strike in the fourth minute; Akash also finds the mark as Jamil's men finish their Group C campaign on a fine, promising note

ASIAN CUP QUALIFIER

P.K. Ajith Kumar
KOCHI

It all looked a bit unreal. Four minutes into the match, two perfect passes met a perfect finish. A naturalised citizen from Australia, playing his first game for India, scored. An excellent crowd erupted in joy.

It was the brightest moment yet in a season of gloom for Indian football. A season that didn't even seem to take off with all the uncertainty regarding the Indian Super League.

But that goal from Ryan Williams brought joy. And there was finally a win for India in the AFC Asian Cup qualifiers, as it beat Hong Kong China 2-1 at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium on Tuesday night.

Coach Khalid Jamil must indeed be a relieved man after India finished its campaign in Group C on such a fine, promising note.

Williams showed how the decision to use eligible foreign-born talents could help Indian football. The 32-year-old from



On a high: Williams is cock-a-hoop after giving the host an early lead. THULASI KAKKAT

Perth had to give up his Australian passport to play for India.

He didn't take long to make his mark in the blue jersey. And he did that in style, too.

It all began with a superb through ball from own half by Abhishek Singh Tekcham, who had Manvir Singh cutting into the box.

Williams smartly put the ball past the Hong Kong

goalkeeper Pong Cheuk Hei. India continued to play with pace and purpose.

Difficult angle

Five minutes after the interval, Akash Mishra doubled the joy for the noisy crowd, finding the target from a difficult angle off a powerful throw-in into the box by Rahul Bheke.

Hong Kong reduced the

margin through Everton Camargo, who was able to dupe the usually tight Indian defence.

But, the home side, cheered on by some 22,000 supporters, ensured this was a night to remember.

The result:

India 2 (Ryan Williams 4, Akash Mishra 50) bt Hong Kong China 1 (Everton Camargo 65).

N R I Triple Power wins Ardent Knight Plate

RACING

HYDERABAD: Trainer D. Netto's filly N R I Triple Power, ridden by Mukesh Kumar, won the Ardent Knight Plate, the main event of Tuesday's (Mar. 31) races here. The winner is owned by Mr. Ravinder Reddy Male. Mukesh Kumar stole the limelight by riding four winners on the day. 1. ZURBARAN PLATE (1,200M): FOXWORTH (Mukesh Kumar) 1, Analysis (G. Nareesh) 2, Mahwish (Ajay K) 3 and Atreya (B. Nikhil) 4. Not run: Santorini Sky, 2-3/4, 1-4 and Nose, 1m, 12.88s. ₹34 (w), 26, 12 and 51 (p). SHP: 34, THP: 68, FP: 97, Q: 73, Tanala: 1,002. Favourite: Zindabad. Owners: Mr. Suchit Jayraj Shah, Mr. Mirza Ayub Baig & The Estate of Late Mr. Rajesh Sanghani. Trainer: D. Netto.

2. CHAITANYA CHAKRAM PLATE (1,400M): N R I RANGE (Akshay Kumar) 1, Dream To Fly (G. Nareesh) 2, First Lady (B.R. Kumar) 3 and Sadiya (P. Ajeeth K) 4. 5-1/2, 2 and 1/2. 1m, 26.50s. ₹24 (w), 15, 13 and 10 (p). SHP: 36, THP: 87, FP: 79, Q: 58, Tanala: 207. Favourite: First Lady. Owner: Mr. Ravinder Reddy Male. Trainer: M. Srinivas Reddy. 3. BHAKRANANGAL PLATE (1,600M): SPECIAL STAR (Mukesh Kumar) 1, Real Thalaiva (Mohit) 2, Lake Michigan (Akshay K) 3 and Quintessential (Kuldeep Jr.) 4. 3-1/2, 1/2 and 3-1/4. 1m, 39.76s. ₹14 (w), 15, 15 and 10 (p). SHP: 48, THP: 23, FP: 102, Q: 73, Tanala: 158. Favourite: Special Star. Owners: M/s. Ashok Ranpise, Seshadri Reddy Pochana, Teegala Vijender Reddy, Teegala Sumant Reddy, Teja Gollapudi, Bollineni Krishnaiah, Capt. Jamshed J. Appo, M/s. Mukund Kakani & Pochana Arjun Reddy. Trainer:

K.S.V. Prasad Raju. 4. ARDENT KNIGHT PLATE (1,600M): N R I TRIPLE POWER (Mukesh Kumar) 1, Authoritarian (Ajay K) 2, Knight Regent (Akshay K) 3 and Krystallos (Surya Prakash) 4. 4-3/4, Short Head and Neck. 1m, 39.18s. ₹33 (w), 20, 12 and 10 (p). SHP: 59, THP: 60, FP: 216, Q: 175, Tanala: 472. Favourite: Knight Regent. Owner: Mr. Ravinder Reddy Male. Trainer: D. Netto. 5. PRINCE OF BERAR PLATE (1,100M): DIVINE TIGER (Akshay Kumar) 1, Queen Eternal (Neeraj) 2, Aarav's Pet (B. Nikhil) 3 and My Day (Rafique Sk.) 4. 2-1/2, 2-1/4 and 1-1/2. 1m, 05.76s. ₹23 (w), 10, 15 and 37 (p). SHP: 46, THP: 157, FP: 68, Q: 63, Tanala: 1,076. Favourite: Grit N Grace. Owner: Mr. Paramvir Singh. Trainer: L.V.R. Deshmukh. 6. CABARET PLATE (1,200M): DECCAN SPIRIT (Mukesh Kumar) 1, Knight Crusader (Akshay K) 2,

Gloria (P. Ajeeth K) 3 and Rival (Ajay K) 4. Not run: Safala, 1/2, 3-3/4 and 3/4. 1m, 11.36s. ₹39 (w), 23, 13 and 16 (p). SHP: 36, THP: 60, FP: 121, Q: 42, Tanala: 911. Favourite: Knight Crusader. Owners: Mr. Shailendra Singh & Mr. K. Ram Gopal Rao. Trainer: Magan Singh. 7. SWEET GIRL PLATE (1,400M): SILVER ARROW (P. Sai Kumar) 1, Bold Indian (Akshay K) 2, Muaser (P. Ajeeth K) 3 and Star Cruise (Kuldeep Jr.) 4. Not run: Golden Bourbon and Lucky Fiero. Neck, 2 and 7-1/4. 1m, 28.57s. ₹23 (w), 19, 10 and 10 (p). SHP: 16, THP: 19, FP: 52, Q: 25, Tanala: 83. Favourite: Bold Indian. Owner: Mr. Ashok Kumar Gupta. Trainer: A. Imran Khan. Jackpot: 70%: ₹4,246 (77 tkts.), 30%: 353 (396 tkts.). Mini Jackpot: (i) 1,029 (21 tkts.), (ii) 2,045 (30 tkts.). Treble: (i) 266 (132 tkts.), (ii) 479 (99 tkts.).

AROUND THE CITY

Income Tax spikers reign

Income Tax (20 points), with an all-win record, won the SNJ Group-Chennai District 'A' Division men's volleyball league championship held here recently. Indian Bank (18) came second while SRM IST (15) emerged third. The winner took home ₹1,50,000.

Mohanraj and Rakshatha win under-15 titles

Mohanraj Venkatesan and S.A. Rakshatha won the boys' and girls' under-25 titles respectively in the 5th ARS Tamil Nadu State-level children's chess tournament, organised by ARS Chess Academy and Tiruvallur District Chess Association, at Sethu Bhaskara MHSS, Ambattur, on Sunday.

The results:
Boys: Under-8: 1. Arshith Subhan 7/7, 2. D.M. Rithviksai 6, 3. Devansh Jain 6; **under-10:** 1. A.B. Charvaka Piy 7, 2. Sarvesh Devaragan 6.5, 3. J. Viraj 6; **under-13:** 1. B. Sai Saran 7, 2. B. Sai Sabarish 6, 3. S. Raghav 6; **under-15:** 1. T.S. Sarath 6.5, 2. Shanibraaz 6, 3. A.N. Jihan Pradhan 5.5.
Under-25: 1. Mohanraj Venkatesan 7, 2. T. Santhosh 5.5, 3. V. Guna 5.5.
Girls: Under-8: 1. Aashvi Vinod 7, 2. Shivanya Arunkumar 6, 3. M. Sheril Mithra 6; **under-10:** 1. R.



Triumphant: The Income Tax volleyball squad with its big prize. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Winning moves: The various champions in the State-level children's chess tournament. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Yuktha 7, 2. I. Rizwana 6, 3. U. Riya Raj 6; **under-13:** Sriya Kumar 6.5, 2. M. Maitreyi 6, 3. N. Sai Divyapriya 5.5.
Under-15: 1. C. Thaniya Shree 5/5, 2. C. Thaniya Shree 4, 3. S.K. Pranathi 4; **under-25:** 1. S.A. Rakshatha 3.5/4, 2. R. Priyanka 3/4, 3. V. Gayathri 3.

Summer camps

Fine Star Cricket Academy will conduct a summer camp for boys and girls from April 1 to May 15 at Annai Violet College of Arts & Science, Ambattur. For details, contact: 8754561894, 9941198920.

Racketry Badminton

Academy will conduct its summer camp from April 16 to May 31. The programme is designed by Aditya Elango (Former World No. 80 in men's singles). The camp will be held at Adambakkam, Chromepet, Injambakkam, Perungudi, Pallikaranai, Porur and Thoraipakkam. Children between five and 17 are eligible.

Contact 98407 98994 (Adambakkam) or 98410 63254 (Chromepet).



Srinath (AG's Office, 6/18); Shreyas (Indian Oil, 116 n.o.); Narasimhan (Kovai Knights, 115); Ibrahim (Triplicane SC, 5/27); Ahamed (Youngsters, 5/39).



Aadhith (Free Lancers, 5/59); Karthik (Indian Oil, 5/73).

Inter-academy cricket tournament

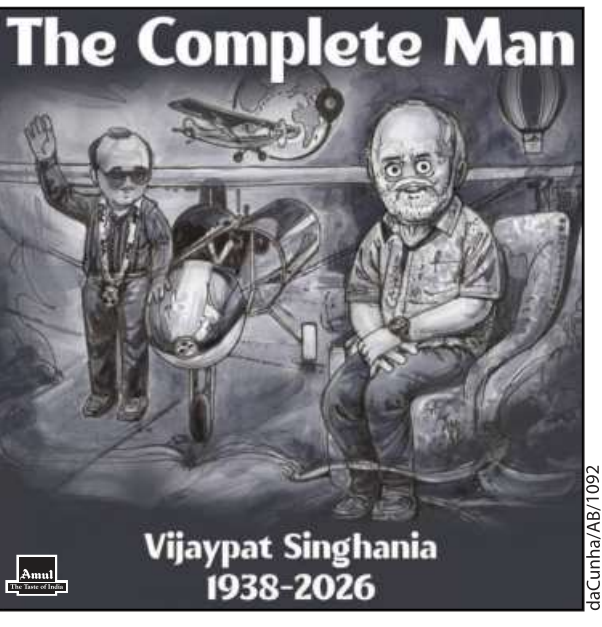
Friends Cricket Academy is conducting an inter-academy tournament for boys under-12 to be played from April 20 at N.M. Greens. Entries open for all academies and clubs. For details, contact, Abdul (9962404093).

World Squash Officiating Refereeing Course

The World Squash Officiating Refereeing Course will be held at the Indian Squash Academy on Wednesday. The session will start at noon.

Srinath claims six in AG's Office's big win

Leg-spinner B. Srinath scalped six for 18 and bowled AG's Office RC to a



Players have to learn to balance life and cricket, says Palani Amarnath

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

Palani Amarnath. Does the name ring a bell? The then unheralded pacer was part of Chennai Super Kings' first-ever IPL match, back in 2008. He picked up a key wicket in his debut outing and played five more games before injury stymied his progress.

He's 43 now and busy shaping careers at the CSK Academy as a coach.

From obscurity to the Super Kings' playing XI was nothing short of memorable for the man from Vellore. "I started playing cricket two-three years before my first IPL match. Prior to that, I was working in a company after finishing my diploma," he told *The Hindu*.

"I was delighted I got a platform like that. That itself is a memory for me. Rubbing shoulders with big stars like (Matthew) Hayden, Mike Hussey, Jacob Oram was a goose-bumps moment. I can't forget that experience."

He said there was pressure on him going into the first match (against the then Kings XI Punjab) but he managed to overcome it. "I was under pressure at the start. We made 240 and it helped me relax a bit," said Palani Amarnath, who scalped the wicket of James Hopes in the 33-run win.



Palani Amarnath. FILE PHOTO: K. PICHUMANI

As luck would have it, injuries happened. He couldn't recover and was no longer the bowler he was. He said there's a lesson in it for the younger crop.

"I tell the trainees that rest is very important. Players have to take care of themselves and their health and learn to balance life and cricket," the former CSK pacer, who has a Level-2 coaching certificate, said.

"It is every cricketer's dream to get a platform like (the IPL). When I watch the IPL, I feel like I missed it. Unfortunately, injuries played a part," said Palani Amarnath, looking back at his career.

Dinesh Kumar 30, Mohamed Ibrahim 5/27, V. Krishnan 3/26) lost to Triplicane SC 186/1 in 28.2 overs (E. Bharathiraja 98, J. Ranjith Kumar 74 n.o.). AG's Office 288/9 in 50 overs (Sreenath Kumar 34, S. Ashwin Balaj 81, P. Francis Rokins 40, K.M. Om Prakash 35, B. Sathish Kumar 31 n.o., R. Adithya 3/40) bt Aruna CC 135 in 29 overs (Sanjay Venkateshwar 41, C. Gourav Sharma 31 n.o, B. Srinath 6/18). **V-D:** Companions CC 241/9 in 50 overs (S. Perumal 54, S. Varun 32, Arun 95, S. Dinesh 3/52, A. Muthukumar 4/40) bt TANGEDCO S & GC 219 in 45.5 overs (N. Boopalan 81, A. Muthukumar 55). Kovai Knights 300 in 47.4 overs (K. Narasimhan 115, Ananth 30, S. Rohit 61, M. Sarath Kumar 30, M.G. Aadhith Retnesh 5/59, G. Vigneshwaran 3/59) bt Free Lancers CC 222/9 in 50 overs (S. Mahesh 53, K. Ajith Kumar 73, Nitish Venugopal 3/32). Indian Oil 280/8 in 50 overs (K.R. Shreyas Raghavan 116 n.o., N. Ganesh 39, P. Kishore Kumar 42, Junaid Mustaq 3/91, H. Balaji 3/57) bt Shivaji CC 237 in 49.3 overs (S. Vigneshwar 57, Junaid Mustaq 43, T.G. Sudharshan 53, A. Karthik Sankar 5/73). Youngsters CC 253 in 49.5 overs (K. Sathish 83, N. Vijay 4/84, S. Yogesh 4/41) bt Chennai P&T Audit 202 in 48.4 overs (Shankar Lal 38, D.R. Remo 51, A. Ahamed Farook Ameen 5/39, J. Sathish Shankar 3/47). TVS MSC 231 in 50 overs (U. Harshan Pranav 51, S.K. Senthilvel 69, A.R. Sayed Seiyath 3/40) lost to Sridhar CC 232/9 in 48.3 overs (S. Sakthivel 41, M.G. Siva Shankar 50, G.K. Nidhish 75, R. Ridam Kumar 3/52, J. Vasanth 3/32).

Anirudh Velamuri

Formula One has always been more than just a sport - it's a theatre of speed, skill, and spectacle. And nowhere is that more evident than in its recent boom in the United States of America, where the *Netflix* hit series 'Drive to Survive' has turned F1 into a cultural phenomenon. The country now hosts three races, with two more just across its northern and southern borders. Alongside the tracks, celebrities, influencers, and industry insiders have flocked to F1 events, while *Apple* reportedly invested \$250-300 million in a Hollywood movie about the sport.

Yet even before the newfound glitz and glamour, drivers had long been striking the right pose. One of them happened in this country not too long ago, when Sebastian Vettel got out of the RB9 and bowed down to it at the 2013 Indian Grand Prix after sealing his fourth world title.

Then there's Daniel Ricciardo and his 'shoey', Michael Schumacher slamming the steering wheel hard enough to break it, Fernando Alonso's emotion-filled scream while standing on top of the Renault R25 and so on. Some were planned, others spontaneous, but each is etched into the sport's folklore.

Enter Kimi Antonelli. Devoted fans knew what celebration to expect from him, yet it slipped amid the chaos of his maiden F1 win in China earlier this month.

"To be fair, I forgot to do it after my first win. I wanted to do the Usain Bolt celebration. I really like Usain Bolt because he's like the fastest man on earth and I really wanted to do it. I love his celebration, I did it in Formula 2 as well but I just forgot it in the moment," he said before the Japanese GP.

That, in a nutshell, encapsulates the youthful exuberance of Antonelli, a teenager whose best laid plans took the backseat as raw emotions took centre stage. Normal service resumed at Suzuka, with Antonelli channelling his inner Bolt after a comfortable victory. For fans, this was just a glimpse of the rising star who is comfortably navigating the cut-throat nature of motorsport's pinnacle.

Fulfilling destiny

Despite the brief dalliance with football when he was younger, it was motorsports that was in Antonelli's destiny, thanks to his early interest in karting as well as his father's established roots in the Italian F4 championship, among others.

Then there's also the small matter of where their house is located: the Antonellis live in an area of Bologna called 'Motor Valley' where Lamborghini, Ducati, Maserati and Ferrari are all based nearby, in addition to the Imola and Modena race tracks.

At age five, Antonelli took the wheel of a go-kart (called Delfino) at the track in Forlì and never looked back. Even as a child, F1 was the ultimate ambition.

"At Hockenheim in 2014, I couldn't get into the paddock because I was too little. My Dad decided to hide me inside a stack of tyres and wheel me through on a trolley. We put an umbrella on top to

Kimi Antonelli – a blend of Senna's soul and Bolt's speed

The 19-year-old, who has given a glimpse of his talent, has justified Mercedes team principal Wolff's decision to fast-track him to the hot seat; the Italian will want to sustain the momentum he has built after wins in China, Japan



REUTERS

make it harder to spot me!" he told Mercedes before his F1 debut.

"I got through and into the pit lane, and my dad's friend got me a pass. I had a look around for an hour and it was such a cool experience - but we always laugh at the story of the trolley."

That said, when the call came from Mercedes team principal Toto Wolff to step up to F1, Antonelli understandably thought it was a joke. For he had not even made his Formula 2 debut by then. But for Wolff, it was no laughing matter, especially since he was picking a rookie to replace seven-time world champion Lewis Hamilton.

"In the car, Kimi is just a monster. When the visor is down, that boy just delivers. It is very rare to see kids win everything they've ever participated in. In F1, these have become the great champions, the likes of Max Verstappen, Michael Schumacher, Ayrton Senna. Kimi has the same great potential," Wolff told *Netflix*.

Antonelli was always earmarked internally as Hamilton's replacement at the Silver Arrows. The latter's move to Ferrari accelerated the timeline.

Clean slate

The 2026 regulation shake-up allowed Mercedes to challenge Red Bull's dominance and halt McLaren's recent success. The W17 became arguably the best car on the grid, and Antonelli, alongside George Russell, was perfectly positioned to capitalise. Pre-season predictions had

tipped Russell for the championship, a notion reinforced by his early win in Melbourne and his Sprint victory in China, where a collision forced Antonelli to battle tooth and nail just to finish fifth.

While Russell basked in the headlines, the younger, less-experienced Italian quietly turned heads. Fans and pundits alike took note of the raw talent Antonelli was displaying, proof that Mercedes had a genuine star in the making.

Antonelli broke through spectacularly, claiming pole position and, despite a tricky start that left him briefly shuffled by Ferrari, fought back to secure his first F1 victory. Before the ink was dry on the record books and before critics could assemble their doubts, he demonstrated in Japan that he was no one-off.

A hint of luck played its part in both wins: Russell's qualifying woes opened the door in China, while a well-timed Safety Car smoothed the way for Antonelli to register back-to-back triumphs. Some might call it "champion's luck."

After the roller-coaster of his rookie 2025 season, Antonelli now appears more composed and level-headed, fully capable of holding his own at the front of the grid.

"Experience does a lot. Obviously, last year I've gone through a lot and it taught me massively more than what I anticipated, and for sure it's helping so far this year. Of course, there's still a lot of work to do, but I definitely feel much more in control of the situation."

While being the youngest person to lead the drivers' championship doesn't make him the favourite to seal the title, the last two races have at least shown that we have a title fight on our hands - even if it is between two teammates. Like a *deja vu* for Mercedes and Wolff.

As for Antonelli, he knows that there's a lot to improve and a month's break comes right in time to aid the same.

"Luckily, I've got three weeks, so now I can practice some clutch drops just to get a better feel with it, because definitely it's been a weak point so far this year and you need to improve that because you can easily win or lose races with that," he said after the Japanese GP.

Not many teenagers bother about their legacies beyond the glamour of triumph. Antonelli, if the early signs are anything to go by, is an outlier here too.

Like a plethora of drivers, he looks up to Senna. He may never have seen the three-time F1 champion race live, but has spent countless hours watching and rewatching Senna's performances, and studying everything the legendary driver accomplished both on and off the track.

Senna's influence is evident even in Antonelli's choice of car number. The Brazilian used the number 12 for three seasons with Lotus, with which he got his

first F1 win (Portugal 1985). He stuck to that number at McLaren, where he won his first world title in 1988.

"It is also the number 1 first used in single-seaters. From F4, I started to use '12' straight away and it worked pretty well. Hopefully, I can carry that on in F1. I was also 12 years old when I joined the Mercedes junior programme, so there is that too."

Antonelli's admiration goes beyond driving prowess. He hopes to emulate Senna's character and empathy as much as his skill.

"Spa when he jumped out the car to turn off the engine because he saw the driver wasn't conscious. He was really special. He wasn't afraid to show his origins. Brazil was in a difficult situation in those years, but he was always proud to be a Brazilian and show that," Antonelli, then in the F2 circuit, said.

"He's not only a good driver but also a person. He was a really empathetic person. My dream is to reach F1 and to achieve a little part of what he achieved during his career. So he's my first influence and inspiration."

Senna set a benchmark so lofty that only a select few have ever come close, and fewer still have surpassed it. It's far too soon to say how close Antonelli might get to matching the Brazilian's legacy. Yet, if the first two races of the season are any indication, he already carries himself with a composure well beyond his years.

On the asphalt where legends are born, Antonelli has begun writing his story and the opening chapters are impossible to ignore. Under the helmet and behind the wheel, he carries more than speed; he carries curiosity, joy, and the quiet audacity to dream. He is a reminder that F1 is as much about the soul of the driver as the machinery beneath him.

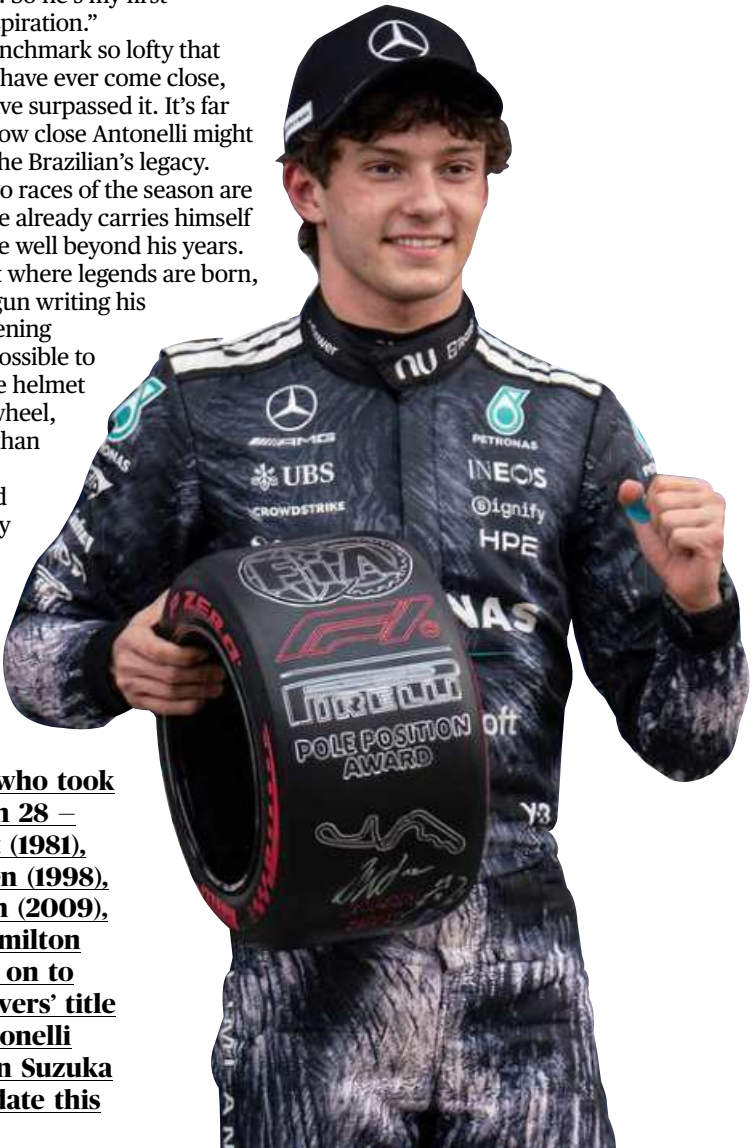
Four drivers who took pole on March 28 – Nelson Piquet (1981), Mika Hakkinen (1998), Jenson Button (2009), and Lewis Hamilton (2015) – went on to clinch the drivers' title that year. Antonelli bagged pole in Suzuka on the same date this year

THE GIST

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Earth’s orbits are filling up because governance hasn’t kept pace

There is no regular way to check whether satellite operators follow through on promises to make satellites safe when they stop working, to move them out of the way or to bring them down once their mission ends; thus, regulators often go by what companies say they will do before launch rather than on what regulators can confirm

Shrawani Shagun
Abhiram Nair

Throughout human history, the sky symbolised freedom – vast, open, untouched. Today, that no longer holds. The earth’s orbital environment has become crowded, fragile, and vulnerable, threatened by what is today evidently a failure of governance rather than just of engineering.

The language of space sustainability has grown familiar in international forums and policy documents. Yet familiarity has bred complacency. As launches become more frequent and the number of private actors multiplies, the gap between what is promised and what is implemented has continued to widen. The result is an orbital environment that is actively used, commercially exploited, and strategically warranted but ethically under-governed.

Orbital harm is difficult to govern because much of the debris capable of causing damage is impossible to track consistently. Authorities are also able to say which fragment came from which object only after it has caused some damage, and even then with limited certainty.

Reducing risk depends on having accurate information about when objects in orbit might come close to one another and exactly where they are.

But access to this information is uneven across satellite operators and countries, and it may be withheld for commercial reasons or kept secret for security reasons.

There’s also no regular way to check whether operators actually follow through on promises to make satellites safe when they stop working, to move them out of the way or to bring them down once their mission ends, especially for small satellites or missions that last only a short time.

As a result, regulators mostly go by what companies say they will do before launch rather than on what regulators can confirm once the satellite is in orbit, which ultimately leaves responsibility unclear.

Responsibility and prevention

Even debris smaller than a coin, travelling at orbital velocities, carries enough energy to disable or destroy active satellites. Each collision generates thousands of new fragments, multiplying risk. International law obligates states to take reasonable measures to prevent foreseeable harm arising from activities under their jurisdiction. In the context of orbital debris, this means states need to plan for collisions, fragmentation, and long-term congestion – but do they? Indeed, choosing not to mitigate risk is itself a decision because it expects others to deal with dangerous situations.

Orbital governance also remains



By dramatically cutting launch costs, reusable boosters allowed SpaceX to deploy the large Starlink satellite constellation at an economically viable scale. SPACEX

anchored in outdated assumptions. The existing treaties were written for an era when space activity was limited, controlled by states, and innovation was slow. Importantly, they do not address cumulative harm and stewardship. Article VI of the Outer Space Treaty makes states internationally responsible for national activities in outer space, including those carried out by private actors. Article VII establishes liability for damage caused by space objects. Yet these provisions were not designed to prevent cumulative harm and are also poorly suited to preventing cumulative harm before it becomes irreversible.

At present, there is no international duty-of-care standard for the earth’s orbits and no ethical threshold for ‘acceptable’ congestion.

National licensing regimes are one of a few mechanisms that can enforce orbital responsibility before damage occurs. Increasingly of late, before they approve a rocket launch or a mission, regulators need to be told the orbital lifetime, the ways in which the payload can be disposed of, whether it has provisions to avoid collisions, and whether it can be passivated (i.e. deprived of the ability to move around). However, regulators in different jurisdictions ask for different levels of details, so operators register in permissive regulatory environments.

To avoid this, licensing conditions need to be standardised, alongside mandating launch operators to use measurable debris-mitigation thresholds, compulsorily share data to improve space situational awareness, and use verifiable end-of-life disposal strategies.

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The ethical vacuum is becoming more pronounced as new actors enter space. Nations entering spaceflight for the first time and private enterprises are central to the future of orbital activity – but will these actors inherit the permissive norms that produced today’s congestion or will they help redefine responsibility for the decades ahead?

Principles embedded in international environmental law, including precaution, proportionality, and intergenerational equity, offer a useful guide. These principles recognise that uncertainty does not excuse inaction and that the way we use (non-rivalrous) resources today should not foreclose future generations’ access to the same resources.

India’s opportunity

The present moment is particularly significant for India. Its space programme has for a long time operated with tight constraints while delivering global services. As commercial participation expands and launch capabilities grow, India can either remain a silent participant or help shape their ethical norms. Specifically, as India develops its national space legislation and licensing

regime, it has a chance to embed orbital responsibility as a legal requirement.

Ethical governance means recognising that shared environments demand shared restraint and that access to orbit carries obligations beyond national interest or commerce. Setting up such a governing system in turn requires us to answer some tough questions first: When does congestion become negligence? Who bears responsibility for cumulative risk? What obligations do present-day operators owe to future spacefarers?

Voluntary guidelines and rhetorical commitments no longer work; instead, governments and private sector enterprises must express the best principles of environmental governance in enforceable terms in space policy. Existing guidelines to mitigate debris in orbit, while being technically sound, rely largely on voluntary compliance and lack uniform monitoring or sanctions for non-compliance. This has resulted in an uneven regulatory landscape in which the responsible operators absorb higher costs.

Space should be sustainable, which means we should be willing to build the ethical governance required to make it so. In space as on the earth, governance that waits for damage before assigning responsibility will arrive too late.

(Shrawani Shagun is a researcher focusing on environmental sustainability and space governance. shrawani.shagun@gmail.com)

Abhiram Nair is a space sustainability researcher and entrepreneur shaping the future of responsible orbits. ceo@erets.uk)

THE GIST

▼ The earth’s orbital environment has become crowded, fragile, and vulnerable, threatened by what is today evidently a failure of governance rather than just of engineering

▼ Reducing risk depends on having accurate information about when objects in orbit might come close to one another and exactly where they are

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BIG SHOT



A drone view shows a skimming boom deployed along the Rio Seco to collect oil after a spill from Pemex’s Olmeca refinery, which is recovering fossil fuels in areas within or adjacent to the facility, in Puerto Ceiba, Mexico on March 20. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Entanglement: spooky action

Vasudevan Mukunth

Scientists have shown that helium atoms can be entangled through their movement. A team from Australia and the U.S. collided clouds of helium atoms together to create pairs that shared a single quantum state.

The achievement showed that even ‘heavy’ particles could follow the same strange quantum physics rules that scientists have mostly observed so far in much lighter particles like electrons. The possibility also opens new ways for researchers to study the link between quantum physics and gravity — a famous unsolved problem in physics.

Quantum entanglement occurs when two particles become so deeply linked that they share a single existence.

The study achieved momentum entanglement, where the link involves the particles’ momentum. When scientists collided the atoms, the resulting pairs flew apart. Because of quantum mechanics, neither atom had a definite direction until a detector measured it. However, once they measured the momentum of one atom, they instantly determined the momentum of its partner, no matter how far apart they’d travelled.

In entanglement, one atom does not disappear and reappear elsewhere. Instead, teleportation involves quantum



Scientists have shown that helium atoms can be entangled through their movement. GETTY IMAGES

information: when a measurement defines the first atom’s state, that information effectively dictates the state of the second atom across the void. Albert Einstein famously called this “spooky action at a distance” because it defies everyday logic. In classical physics, objects usually only affect things directly next to them. Momentum entanglement proves that whole atoms can remain connected through a nonlocal bond.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Audit queries ignored by Maharashtra departments

10,340 The Comptroller and Auditor General of India has flagged “systemic deficiencies” in Maharashtra’s governance, identifying ₹891 crore in possible financial irregularities across more than 10,000 audit queries that various departments ignored despite repeated reminders over a decade. PTI

The percentage surge in Indonesian forest loss in 2025

66 percent. Forest loss in Indonesia surged by 66 percent in 2025, hitting its highest rate in eight years as a result of weak environmental protections and an ambitious food and energy self-sufficiency drive, an environmental group said on Tuesday. The archipelago leans heavily on mining and palm plantations to support its \$1.4 trillion economy. REUTERS

The average monthly mobile data usage per user in India last year

31 GB India’s average monthly mobile data consumption per user crossed the 31 GB mark in 2025, up from 27.5 GB in 2024, according to a report by telecom gear maker Nokia. India boasts the world’s second-largest 5G subscriber base, the second-highest level of 5G data consumption, and the second-largest 5G Fixed Wireless Access user base globally, the report says. PTI

RBI borrowings availed by Telangana for most of FY25

27,730 in ₹ crore. The Telangana government availed a Special Drawing Facility (SDF) of ₹27,730 crore from the RBI for 363 days to meet its financial requirements. According to the 2024-25 annual account, the State also utilised Ways and Means Advances amounting to ₹64,188 crore for 298 days. PTI

Funds released by the Centre under Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0

1,561.53 in ₹ crore The Jal Shakti ministry has released funds of ₹1,561.53 crore for five States under the Jal Jeevan Mission 2.0 for 2025–26, after signing reform-linked MoUs, and fulfilment of mandatory compliance conditions, an official statement said on Tuesday. PTI

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On global tensions and India’s economy

In an economy that imports more than four-fifths of its crude oil, external shocks transmitted through energy prices, shipping route, and volatile commodity markets can significantly reshape fiscal arithmetic. In this context, India must rebalance toward income-led demand, more resilient revenue bases and greater energy diversification

ECONOMIC NOTES

Deepanshu Mohan

Rising geopolitical instability in West Asia is forcing a reassessment of how India’s macroeconomic strength is measured.

As of March 2026, this instability has translated into active macroeconomic stress. The rupee has depreciated to a record low of ₹95 per dollar, the Indian basket of crude oil hit \$156.29 per barrel, and the Reserve Bank of India has deployed billions of dollars of foreign exchange reserves to contain volatility. In such conditions, strong quarterly GDP prints capture domestic activity but often overlook vulnerabilities linked to energy imports, shipping routes and fiscal buffers.

Against this backdrop, India enters the post-Budget season with a striking macroeconomic contradiction. Headline indicators remain robust: the State Bank of India expects Q3 FY26 GDP growth of about 8.1 percent, public capital expenditure is near 4 percent of GDP, and fiscal consolidation toward a 4.3 percent deficit by FY27 remains intact. At the same time, external buffers are weakening. Foreign exchange reserves have declined from recent highs to about \$709.76 billion, while foreign portfolio outflows of over \$8 billion following the onset of the conflict have intensified currency pressures.

Yet income dynamics are weaker. Real wages remain subdued, household liabilities have risen to roughly 41 percent of GDP, and private investment continues to lag the state’s capex-led expansion.

This divergence reflects a deeper shift in India’s fiscal architecture: revenue buoyancy is increasingly driven by transaction-linked taxation while expenditure tilts toward capital formation. In a stable global environment this model can sustain growth, but when energy markets become volatile, its durability depends on whether fiscal revenues, consumption and investment can withstand external commodity shocks.

Shifts in revenue structure

India’s revenue structure has been shifting in ways that matter more in a volatile global environment. Revenue receipts have risen from 8.5 percent of GDP in FY16-20 to about 9.1 percent in FY22-FY25 (PA), but the increase reflects recomposition rather than a broadening of income taxation. The Union Budget 2026-27 estimates gross tax revenue at ₹44.04 lakh crore, yet much of the buoyancy now comes from transaction-linked channels. GST collections reached ₹22.8 lakh crore in FY25, while levies on financial and cross-border transactions have also expanded.

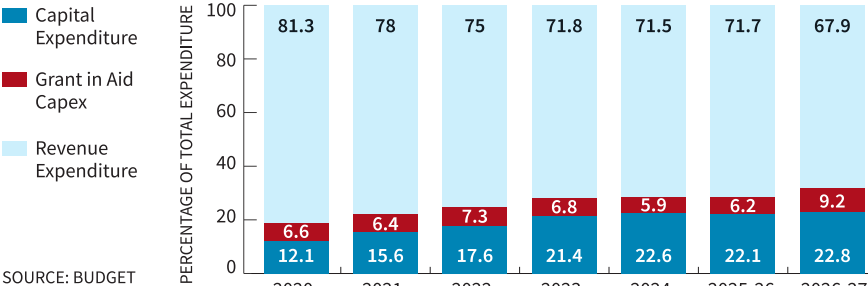
Direct taxes typically expand when more workers move into stable paid employment. As a result, revenue growth increasingly depends on the volume of economic transactions rather than income deepening.

External shocks particularly energy price spikes that raise transport costs and compress household spending can quickly slow transactions. In such conditions, a fiscal model reliant on activity-linked taxation becomes more sensitive to geopolitical disruptions that ripple through consumption, trade and financial markets.

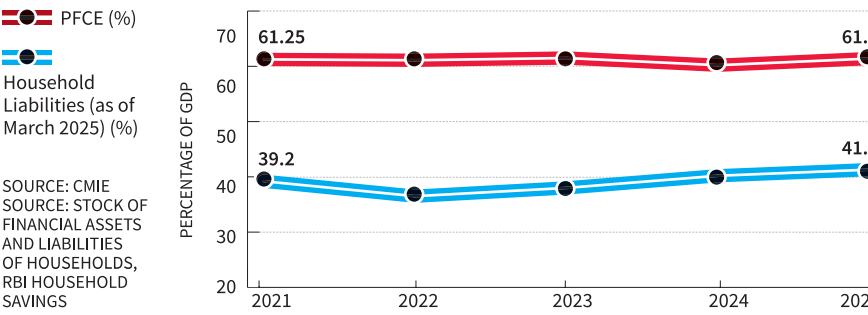
This vulnerability has been evident

Fiscal trends

India’s fiscal stability is tied to capital spending and transaction-based revenues, leaving it vulnerable to energy shocks amid geopolitical tensions



SOURCE: BUDGET AT A GLANCE 2026-27



SOURCE: CMIE
SOURCE: STOCK OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND LIABILITIES OF HOUSEHOLDS, RBI HOUSEHOLD SAVINGS



during past shocks. During the pandemic, widening gaps between projected and actual GST revenues forced the Union government to borrow over ₹2.69 lakh crore between 2020 and 2022 to compensate states for revenue shortfalls.

The effects of oil price surge

India’s fiscal system remains structurally exposed to oil price volatility. The country imports around 85-87 percent of its crude oil, making it directly vulnerable to external energy shocks.

Empirical estimates suggest that a \$10 per barrel rise in crude prices can increase Consumer Price Index inflation by roughly 0.2 percentage points, widen the current account deficit by about \$9-10 billion (around 0.4 percent of GDP) and reduce GDP growth by nearly 0.5 percentage points under partial pass-through conditions. Oil shocks also propagate through the fiscal system: higher energy costs raise fertiliser and LPG subsidy requirements, increase transport and logistics costs, and elevate inflation-linked expenditure.

Recent policy responses illustrate this transmission. Following the Russian invasion of Ukraine, the Indian crude basket surged from roughly \$59 per barrel in 2019 to over \$120 in mid-2022.

To contain inflation, the government reduced central excise duties on petrol and diesel by a cumulative ₹13 and ₹16 per litre between November 2021 and May 2022, resulting in an estimated ₹2.2 lakh crore revenue loss. At the same time, energy-linked subsidies expanded, with fertiliser support rising sharply and total energy subsidies touching nearly ₹3.2 lakh crore.

Amid the ongoing conflict in West Asia, estimates by ICRA suggest that if oil prices average around \$100 per barrel, India’s current account deficit could widen from about 0.7-0.8 percent to nearly 1 percent of GDP, while government expenditure could rise by as much as ₹3.6 trillion due to higher subsidy and compensation requirements. This underscores how energy shocks translate simultaneously into external imbalances and fiscal stress.

When oil prices spike, governments typically absorb part of the shock through tax reductions and subsidy expansion, compressing fiscal space. In a system increasingly reliant on transaction-linked taxes, such shocks can simultaneously weaken consumption, reduce GST buoyancy and expand expenditure pressures, creating a direct fiscal squeeze.

Impact on households

Household balance sheets reveal a key channel through which energy volatility transmits into the domestic economy.

Private consumption accounts for roughly 61.4 percent of India’s GDP, yet household liabilities have risen sharply from about 36-37 percent of GDP in 2022 to over 41 percent by 2025, increasing sensitivity to inflationary shocks and suggesting that consumption is being sustained less by income growth and more through credit expansion.

Net financial savings have also become more volatile, falling to around 3-4 percent of GDP in recent quarters before recovering to about 7.6 percent.

The exposure is being amplified by the current shock, as disruptions to LPG supply chains – over 60 percent of which depend on imports – have translated into

longer refill cycles and local shortages, raising household energy costs even as leverage remains elevated.

At the same time, India’s expenditure strategy has pivoted toward infrastructure-led growth. The Union Budget 2026-27 places effective capital expenditure at ₹17.15 lakh crore.

While such front-loaded investment strengthens long-term productive capacity, it compresses fiscal space for welfare stabilisers. Allocations for the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act fell to ₹60,000 crore in 2023-24, 33 percent below the previous year’s revised estimate; by December 2022, States had already spent 117 percent of available funds, with ₹8,449 crore in pending liabilities.

In a low-wage environment, imported energy inflation compresses real incomes while debt servicing obligations remain fixed. Rising household leverage therefore becomes a macroeconomic vulnerability, especially when fiscal policy prioritises capital formation over income support.

Implications for industrial sector

India’s industrial upswing is increasingly concentrated in capital-intensive sectors aligned with public investment. Industrial output rose 7.8 percent in December 2025, with manufacturing expanding 8.1 percent year-on-year and 4.8 percent over April-December. High- and medium-technology industries now account for about 46 percent of manufacturing value added, according to the Economic Survey 2025-26.

By contrast, labour-intensive industries remain weak.

Private investment remains cautious despite rising project announcements.

CMIE (Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy) data shows private firms account for nearly 80 percent of new project announcements, yet only about 9 percent reached completion in 2022-23, suggesting a recovery that expands production capacity more than wage-linked income.

In a volatile global environment, this financial strength has translated into greater risk selectivity rather than broader credit expansion.

The recent LPG crisis induced shortages of commercial cylinders have forced the closure of restaurants, cloud kitchens and small food businesses, with gig worker unions reporting a 50-60 percent decline in food delivery orders. Such shocks disproportionately affect labour-intensive and informal sectors, where incomes are directly tied to daily demand and lack institutional protection, even as capital-intensive sectors remain relatively insulated within the financial system.

As external pressures intensify, they raise a broader question of fiscal optionality: the state’s ability to absorb shocks without abandoning consolidation targets. With fiscal space tied to capital expenditure and revenues dependent on economic transactions, geopolitical disruptions can quickly narrow the room for counter-cyclical intervention. In such a context, India must rebalance toward income-led demand, more resilient revenue bases and greater energy diversification, or risk turning external shocks into a recurring source of fiscal stress.

(Deepanshu Mohan is professor and dean, O.P. Jindal Global University. He is a visiting professor at LSE and a visiting academic fellow at University of Oxford. Saksham Raj and Aditi Lazarus contributed to this column.)

THE GIST

India’s fiscal system remains structurally exposed to oil price volatility. External shocks, particularly energy price spikes raise transport costs and compress household spending.

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